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PARLIAMENTARY DEBATES

OFFICIAL REPORT

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THE
PARLIAMENT OF THE REPUBLIC
OF GHANA

THIRD MEETING, 2025

Wednesday, 26th November, 2025

*The House met at the Chamber,
Parliament House, at 12:41 p.m.*

[HON SECOND DEPUTY SPEAKER,
MR ANDREW ASIAMAH AMOAKO,
IN THE CHAIR]

[PRAYERS]

Mr Second Deputy Speaker: Hon Members, let us turn to the item numbered 5 on the *Order Paper*—Correction of *Votes and Proceedings* and the *Official Report*.

**VOTES AND PROCEEDINGS AND
THE OFFICIAL REPORT**

Mr Second Deputy Speaker: We would start with the *Votes and Proceedings* of Tuesday, 25th November, 2025.

Page 1...10—Yes, Hon Deputy Minister for the Interior?

Mr Ebenezer Okletay Terlarbi: Mr Speaker, I was here yesterday, but I have been marked absent.

Mr Second Deputy Speaker: Were you here and did you sign in?

Mr Terlarbi: I did.

Mr Second Deputy Speaker: Table, kindly crosscheck if indeed he signed. I am not saying that he was not here, but the mistake we always make is that, we forget to sign—

Mr Terlarbi: I signed.

Mr Second Deputy Speaker: Table, kindly acknowledge that.

Page 11...12—

Yes, First Deputy Minority Whip?

Alhaji Habib Iddrisu: Mr Speaker, on the page numbered 12, the item numbered 2, stated in the *Votes and Proceedings* as “Clauses 51 to 67, agreed to”—I think yesterday, the Minority Leader raised concerns about Clause 56 and it was stood down for further deliberations. So, if they write “Clauses 51 to 67, agreed to”, then 56—

Mr Second Deputy Speaker: The information I have is that you are right. Initially, they stood it down. But later, the First Deputy Speaker, who was presiding, put the Question and it was agreed to.

Page 12...16—

Yes, Hon Member for Afadjato South?

Mr Frank Afriyie: Mr Speaker, I am most grateful and welcome back.

Mr Speaker, on the item numbered (xv), let us delete the word written after “DO1” and insert the name “Michael”.

Thank you.

Mr Second Deputy Speaker: Why do you want us to delete the word “DO1”

Mr Afriyie: Mr Speaker, I said the word written after “DO1” should be deleted. They were attempting to spell “Michael” and inadvertently spelt something else.

Thank you.

Mr Second Deputy Speaker: Please, just correct the word “Micheal” as wrongly spelt on the page numbered 17, the item numbered (xv).

Page 18...20

Hon Members, the *Votes and Proceedings* of Tuesday, 25th November, 2025, as corrected, is hereby adopted as the true record of proceedings.

Mr Second Deputy Speaker: Hon Members, we have the *Official Report* of Thursday, 13th November, 2025, for correction.

[No correction was made to the Official Report of Thursday, 13th November, 2025]

Mr Second Deputy Speaker: Leadership, are we going on with Questions or we would go on with the debate?

Majority Chief whip (Mr Rockson-Nelson Etse Dafeamekpor): Mr Speaker, we would follow yesterday’s protocol and proceed with the commentaries on the Budget Statement and Economic Policy.

Yesterday, we agreed that if the time permits us, we would take contributions from nine Members from both Sides, so, that would be 18 in all. We have nine Members who are ready. The indication from the First Deputy Minority Whip is that, he also has the nine Members contributing, ready.

12:51 p.m.

The only difficulty we have is that it was good for us to deal with the Bills that were laid yesterday for an hour before we zoom into taking commentaries from Members. The Chairman of the Committee is around the corner and if he comes in we can continue with the amendments and we will move to the Consideration stage and finish with Amendments. We had about 15 clauses to deal with except one or two that were intractable yesterday so once we deal with those ones this early afternoon then we can spend the rest of the time on the commentaries. I do not know what the pleasure of my Hon Brother from across the divide is in this matter.

Alhaji Habib Iddrisu: Mr Speaker, I do not think we have any difficulty in the suggestions that the Majority Chief Whip gave except that the Chairman of the Committee with regard to the Value Added Tax Bill, 2025 is not here. So, since the Chairman is not here yet, we can start with the commentary on the Budget Statement and Economic Policy when he arrives then we can continue.

Mr Dafeamekpor: Mr Speaker, I agree with my Hon Brother but we have four commemorative Statements admitted,

they have been outstanding for so long and they are commemorative. Fortuitously, the Member for North Dayi is here.

Mr Speaker, with your leave we can take the commemorative Statement. I am sure that by the time she is done with her Statement, we would be set for Government Business.

Alhaji Habib Iddrisu: Mr Speaker, I do not know why the Majority Leader is not saying anything and the Majority Chief Whip who was not at pre-Sitting meeting is the one talking. We had some agreements. We arranged and we agreed to certain things and that Statement was not part of what was agreed at Conclave. We agreed that the list can be done or we can do the Value Added Tax Bill, 2025. So, if we take that, we would totally deviate from what has been agreed on. Let us start with the commentary if the Chairman is not here yet. If we start early, we can be able to finish and consider other Statements but that was not what was agreed.

Mr Dafeamekpor: Mr Speaker, I agree. I was not at pre-Sitting meeting but my Leader was there. I was also engaged on another Business of the House. I am saying that given the exigencies, her Statement is just about one and a half pages. I am sure by the time she is done with her Statement; we would be set to deal with the issues that my Hon Brother is raising. I do not think it is fatal. Do not let us litigate this. If we had allowed her, I am sure she would have finished by now.

Alhaji Habib Iddrisu: Mr Speaker, I am tempted to believe that the Majority Side is not ready to debate or comment on their own Budget Statement and Economic Policy. They are running away from their own Budget Statement commentary. Let us comment on the Budget Statement and Economic Policy because Leaders are concluding tomorrow. We agreed on this yesterday, even before we adjourned and at Conclave, we agreed as well. So, pulling surprises on us now would not be entertained.

Mr Speaker, if they are not ready for the debate, they should let us know but that was not what we agreed on.

Mr Second Deputy Speaker: Hon Leaders, I would make time for the commemorative Statements. Hon Dafeamekpor, let us start with the comments, I would make time for the commemorative Statements. So, Hon Member, hold on, let us start as we agreed at Conclave. We would pause and give you the opportunity to read the Statement.

Mr Dafeamekpor: Mr Speaker, very well. On our list, we have nine Members.

Mr Second Deputy Speaker: I do not have your list.

Mr Dafeamekpor: It is here. The Hon Member who is to start today, the Hon Chairman for the Committee on Education is here.

So, Mr Speaker, the commentaries can flow.

Mr Second Deputy Speaker: Very well, let me have your list. I do not have it.

So where are we starting from today? Is it from Minority or Majority Side? Yesterday, I realised there was a bit of —

Mr Dafeamekpor: Mr Speaker, either Side will do. We are not minded, so either Side will do.

Mr Second Deputy Speaker: Which Side started yesterday?

Alhaji Habib Iddrisu: Mr Speaker, they always start.

Mr Second Deputy Speaker: Yesterday, the Majority started. All right, then I would start from —

Alhaji Habib Iddrisu: Mr Speaker, no, it is not the case. They always, start. We ended yesterday, so they will always start, and it has always been like that. We should not change it.

Mr Speaker, I do not know why the Majority is afraid of the mighty Minority in starting their commentary. Start your commentary, and we would set the record straight.

Mr Speaker, let them start. It has always been the case. It has never been the case that we rotate who starts. They should start, the Chairman of the Committee on Education is there. He is seated and ready. Let him make his comments and if there are things that we need to straighten up, then I will be able to respond.

Mr Second Deputy Speaker: Yes, Hon Peter Kwasi Nortsu-Kotoe, you would start. As Chairman of the Committee on Education, you have 15 minutes.

STATEMENT

Government's Financial Policy, 2026

[Resumption of commentary from 25/11/2025]

Mr Peter Kwasi Nortsu-Kotoe (NDC — Akatsi North): Mr Speaker, I want to thank you once again for giving me the opportunity to make comments on the Budget Statement and Economic Policy of the Government of Ghana for the year 2026, with the theme, “Resetting for Growth, Jobs, and Economic Transformation”, delivered by Hon Dr Cassiel Ato Forson, Minister for Finance, on behalf of the President of the Republic of Ghana, His Excellency John Dramani Mahama.

Mr Speaker, I wish to first of all give some information as to what is happening in the education sector in this country.

Mr Speaker, it is a known fact that since the beginning of this year, our students in the senior high schools and technical institutes under the Free SHS programme are no longer fed with weevil-infested beans. It is also important to note that our students are no longer fed with expired, repackaged rice. It is also a fact that our students no longer take tea at breakfast without bread and I can add that they now take breakfast with eggs—*[Hear! Hear!]*.

Mr Speaker, at the beginning of this year, January 2025, it was so crucial that if immediate action had not been taken, our students were going to go hungry. The previous Government had not made any provision for the term beginning in January, 2025. So, the Chief of Staff had to put in place stringent measures for a committee to be consulted to meet so that we could arrange for the supply of foodstuffs to senior high schools and I want to appreciate the heads of the assisted senior high schools for the role they played. As we speak now, purchase of food items at the senior high schools is decentralised. We no longer expect Buffer Stock to supply food items from Accra to Tamale Senior High School, Wa Senior High School, Ave Senior High School in Akatsi North or Peki Senior High School in South Dayi.

1:01p.m.

Mr Speaker, it is also on record that currently Government spends over GH¢51 million a week to feed students in our senior high schools. I will not give you any source, but it is a fact.

Mr Speaker, we approved the Budget for 2025, and I am telling them that this is the calculation we have in the 2025 Budget; GH¢51 million a week to feed students. So, we would realise that, with decentralisation, heads have free hands in managing the procurement of food items in their schools, and this has even given them a voice, and now they can talk. Previously, they were unable to talk. Now that they procure the food items, there are no comments or trouble anymore. That is what we are resetting for Ghana.

Mr Speaker, it is also on record that last year, or a few years ago, it was difficult for the Government to release money to the West African Examinations Council (WAEC) to organise internal examinations such as the Basic Education Certificate Examination (BECE) and the West African Senior School Certificate Examination (WASSCE). In this Chamber, if the Hon Minority Chief were here, he would confirm that he and I had to work hard, together with Mr Agbodza at the time, to make sure that moneys were released by the Ministry of Finance to WAEC, because they were threatening to postpone the conduct of the two examinations last year. We had to make sure that as we speak today, the Government does not owe WAEC even a cedi for the 2025 BECE and the WASSCE. What do we want again? This is the way we have to reset the agenda for education in this country.

Our students should not be left stranded because the Government is unable to pay registration fees for their examinations. The Committee on Education in May this year visited a number of senior high schools in some selected regions, and what we saw was very bad. For example, furniture was a big challenge. We visited Aburi Girls' Senior High School, one of the category A schools that we have in this country, and students were sitting on "Ghana-must-go" as chairs, but if you go there today, they are using very good furniture. That is because the reset agenda in education is working. We also visited the Presbyterian Secondary Technical School, also in Aburi. Some Hon Members here

were there and they saw the furniture situation there. We have been able to provide them with furniture, and everything is going well. That is the Reset Agenda.

Mr Speaker, we have promised Ghanaians that the obnoxious Double-Track system will be abolished in the next two years. Mr Speaker, you were once a member of the Committee on Education, and you knew what was going on. You would realise that it did not help in achieving quality education at all, and that it must be abolished. That one is very important, because school calendars must be the same for all students. They must all go to school at the same time and break at the same time. As I speak now, one year group is at home, waiting for another group to go on holiday before they can also go. That is not the best way to go, and that is why the Minister for Finance and the Minister for Education are promising Ghanaians that in two years, the Double-Track system will be out of the scene.

Mr Speaker, it is also interesting to note that this year, we have brought on board 70 private senior high schools as part of the Free SHS programme, and information available shows that it is going well. Next year, we will have it expanded, because once they are on board, we are sure that it is one way to eliminate the Double-Track in our senior high schools.

Mr Speaker, when we went to the schools, we saw so many abandoned and stalled projects. Some schools have as many as five, six, or ten projects

abandoned at various levels. This Government is determined to make sure that those projects that were started in 2016 in preparation for the Free SHS programme, which their government came and abandoned— They abandoned the E-blocks, the dormitories, the dining hall projects among others. But I can assure this House that work is being done to make sure that these projects are completed, and we will be able to eliminate the Double-Track in the next two years.

Mr Speaker, the immediate past government only renamed universities in this country. They failed to add new ones. We would make sure that in this Budget, a number of universities are going to be established this year.

Mr Speaker, in 2016, a loan agreement was signed and money was made available for the establishment of a campus of the University of Environmental and Sustainable Development Studies at Donkorkrom. Their government, the past government, diverted that loan from Donkorkrom to Bunso, denying the good people of Donkorkrom that opportunity. But I can assure this House that per this Budget, the University of Engineering and Agricultural Science at Bunso will have a campus at Donkorkrom, Kenyansi, and Acherensua. So, that is number one on the issue of universities. The next one will be two technical universities. We would have two new technical universities at Jasikan and Techiman. It is our policy that every region should have at least one public university. They created the regions, but they failed to provide them with those

facilities. We can assure them that next year onwards, we would provide these regions with technical universities, as well as public universities in Kintampo and Dambai. What do you think we should be able to do again in education as far as this is concerned?

Mr Speaker, it is also on record that Parent Teacher Associations (PTAs) were not given the room to operate under the previous governments. But as we speak, PTAs have been reinstated. They are no more Parent Associations (PAs), but the PTA has been restored. We all know the role PTAs play in the educational development of this country. But for eight years, we have denied them the role they play in the development of education in this country? Currently, they are back, and I am happy that they have started well, and they will continue to contribute towards the provision of quality education in the country.

Mr Speaker, it is also on record that for the first time in about eight or nine years, the Capitation Grant is not in arrears. School authorities need this small amount of money to do some repairs that need to be done. But what do we see? The moneys were in arrears over the years. Today, all these arrears have been cleared, and we are current on the payment of the Capitation Grants. We assure this House that this year and years to come, schools in this country will be what our children should attend.

Mr Speaker, we would realise that our institutions are now becoming better than they used to be. That culture of silence is no more there. We are making

sure that they voice whatever concerns they have. Headmasters are free to talk; teachers can talk without intimidation. So that era of intimidation they suffered is over.

1:11 p.m.

Mr Speaker, we also know that we promised automatic recruitment of teachers. Teachers who left colleges in 2023 and 2024 are still at home, but we can assure them that the Minister for Finance will grant clearance and these teachers will be recruited. We cannot train the teachers and leave them at home while the classrooms are empty. But take it from us that things will be better than we had come to meet it. We promised to remove the licensure exam and it is going to happen because it has been integrated into the curriculum of Colleges of Education and that is the way to go.

Mr Speaker, before I sit down, I want to thank the Minister for Roads and Highways on the Big Push project.—*[Hear! Hear!]*—We had the years of roads from 2020 to 2022, but the whole Denu Road was there, but nothing was done to it. As we speak, contractors are busy working on the road. *[Hear! Hear!]* So, Hon Minister for Roads and Highways, congratulations to you and His Excellency, the President of the Republic of Ghana.

On that note, Mr Speaker, I thank you very much for the opportunity.

Mr Second Deputy Speaker: Thank you very much. Let me now turn to the Minority and invite Hon John Darko to take his bite.

Mr John Darko (NPP — Suame):

Thank you very much, Mr Speaker, for the opportunity given to me to comment on the Budget Statement and Economic Policy as presented by the Hon Minister for Finance.

Mr Speaker, by way of preliminary comments, I would like to remind the Minister for Education that from what he just said, he is trying to tell the people of Ghana that the double track will end in 2027—

Mr Second Deputy Speaker: The Minister for Education is not here.

Mr Darko: The Chairperson of the Committee on Education, Mr Speaker.

Mr Second Deputy Speaker: Very well.

Mr Darko: Mr Speaker, at page 79, paragraph 560 of the Budget Statement and Economic Policy, this is what the Minister for Finance told the people of Ghana. Mr Speaker, with your permission, I read. He said:

“Mr Speaker, Government has expanded the Free SHS Programme to include 70 private schools through the Computerised School Placement System to eliminate the double track system. Ongoing projects in public SHSs will be completed to facilitate a full transition to single track by 2026.”

So, what is the Chairman of Committee on Education saying? What he is telling the people of Ghana is

completely different from what the Minister for Finance told us. And so, he was just misleading this House. The Budget is so clear, the Minister for Finance said 2026, and he is here telling us 2027. Who should we believe? Should we believe him, the Minister for Finance, or the Minister for Education? Who do we believe? It looks like this is a confused government.

Mr Dafeamekpor — rose —

Mr Second Deputy Speaker: Hon Majority Chief Whip, would you spare us so that the next speaker will address any mis—He was your roommate?

Mr Dafeamekpor: Mr Speaker, we shared one room for four years in the university, so I would not have done this to him, but Mr Speaker, in pursuance to Order 122 (1) (c), the Chairperson of the Committee on Education was very clear; he said next year. We are speaking in 2025, and next year is 2026. So, he was very clear. There was no ambiguity. So, the Hon Member should not place any ambiguity on what the Chairperson of the Committee on Education said in his commentary. The Hon Member should stay on course, 2026 is what the Chairman said.

Mr Second Deputy Speaker: Hon Members, if you would indulge me, I am not going to entertain this kind of interruptions. If you think what a Member is saying is not right, just jot it down. Once you get the opportunity, you address it. Let us do it that way so that we can get the flow of the comments. Please let us do that way.

Yes, Hon First Deputy Minority Whip?

Alhaji Habib Iddrisu: Mr Speaker, you should not have given the Majority Chief Whip the opportunity then. Now that you have opened that box, if we also think that their argument is in breach of our Orders, you would have to listen to us. Yesterday, the Speaker himself and the First Deputy Speaker allowed Members under Order 123 or 122 to interrupt the debate. If you decide not to allow, they will mislead the House. So, we should be allowed in instances that we think that somebody is misleading the House or on a point of order to interrupt the debate. Because that is exactly what he did. So, we should be given an opportunity to also do the same.

Mr Second Deputy Speaker: Hon Members, I am presiding today, and this is the way I want to go. So, indulge me. I will not entertain any interruptions so that we can flow and get this job done early enough. Yesterday, we spent a lot of time because of these interjections. So, I am not going to entertain that.

Yes, Hon John Darko, let us hear from you.

Mr Darko: Thank you, Mr Speaker. I hope I get my time back.

Mr Speaker, just to make that point again, last week, the Minister for Education was very emphatic about these two years, and so, I am surprised that the Chairperson of the Committee on Education will contradict the Minister. And even in their Budget Statement and

Economic Policy, the Minister for Finance was very clear that this is going to start next year. So, we want to see the consistency from the Side of Government because, at this point, it looks to me that there is no consistency.

Mr Speaker, I would like to move to the energy sector and deal with some of the issues raised in the Budget Statement and Economic Policy, and with your permission, if I may read paragraphs 861, 863 and 864 of the Budget Statement and Economic Policy as presented. The Minister for Finance made some startling revelations in my view. He stated:

“In line with section 27 of the Petroleum Revenue Management Act 815, the Investment Advisory Committee on Investment Policy and Management of the Ghana Petroleum Funds”

Mr Speaker, as a people, we really need to understand what is meant when we say “Ghana Petroleum Funds”, it includes the Ghana Heritage Funds and then the Ghana Stabilisation Funds. Now the Minister for Finance is saying that he has been advised to move this Ghana Petroleum Funds into another investment.

Mr Speaker, at paragraph 863, this is what he had to say:

“Under the current legal framework, investments from the GPFs are restricted to low-risk, foreign-denominated securities issued by entities outside Ghana, such as the IMF, World Bank, and other top-rated sovereigns.”

That is the case; to protect the wealth of this nation, the savings of this country.

1:21 p.m.

But he goes on to say in paragraph 864 that “Unfortunately, this approach has yielded very little returns.” He said that since the establishment of these funds in 2011, total reserves have reached—Mr Speaker, when the Minister for Finance speaks, we should listen to him well. He stated that total reserves had reached US\$1.46 billion. Yet, the only interest that has accrued is US\$1.94 million and an average return of 1 per cent per year. This is what the Minister for Finance is telling the people of Ghana. Yet, on page 71 of the 2025 Public Interest Accountability Committee (PIAC) report, which receives its report from Bank of Ghana, and Mr Speaker, with your permission, if I may read, it says that:

“From August 2011 to June 2025, cumulative petroleum receipts distributed sum up to US\$11 billion.”

Now, Mr Speaker, the interesting part here is that it says that the Ghana Stabilisation Fund received US\$2.6 billion and the Ghana Heritage Fund received US\$1.1 billion. The total of the Ghana Stabilisation Fund and the Ghana Heritage Fund is US\$3.7 billion, and yet, the Minister for Finance is telling Ghanaians that they received US\$1.94 million, and then goes on to say that the interest the country has received from this US\$1.46 billion is actually US\$1.94 million. He said this in November 2025.

Mr Speaker, the US\$1.9 million he referred to as interest from the investment is here in the 2024 report. The Minister for Finance is quoting the interest from our Petroleum Fund from the 2024 documents when we are in 2025. So I am asking myself, what kind of data are they feeding the people of Ghana? Whose interest do they serve? Mr Speaker, I want to go to page 78 of the 2024 PIAC report, which says that:

“Ghana Petroleum Fund’s net profit since November stands at US\$1.94 million.”

That is what the Minister for Finance is telling us in November 2025. There is a new PIAC report for 2025, and the Minister for Finance does not even know.

But you know what, Mr Speaker? I know why. I know why the Minister for Finance wants the people of Ghana to believe that our Petroleum Fund has received only US\$1 billion when it is US\$3 billion. I know why the Minister for Finance is telling us that the only interest we have is US\$1.94 million. Mr Speaker, on 12th November, the Minister for Finance brought a memorandum to this House to tell the people of Ghana to stop investing in the safe bonds. They now want to take our 3.6 billion, which they have reported as 1.6 billion. According to them, they want to invest in some energy sector development in this country. This will deny the people of Ghana and the future generation their interests.

Mr Speaker, section 20 of the Petroleum Management Act (PRMA) talks about the fact that at the end of the petroleum business, when our oil reserves have depleted, the Ghana Heritage Fund and the Ghana Stabilisation Fund will come together to form the Ghana Wealth Fund. But do we know what the Minister for Finance is trying to do? He is trying to spend the Ghana Wealth Fund now. This is what the Minister for Finance is trying to do.

Mr Speaker, if we were to look at the Budget Statement and Economic Policy from this angle, it violates all the principles of sustainable development. Sustainable development meets the needs of the current generation without compromising the ability of future generations to meet their own needs. What this Budget does is to deprive the future generation of their needs.

Mr Speaker, when we look at the Budget, we will see that the Minister for Finance is not serving the interests of the people of Ghana; he is not serving the interests of the future generation. This Budget is, "let us eat now and forget the future generation." Is that what the people of Ghana voted for them for? They were supposed to protect the interests of everybody, including the future generation.

This Budget lacks the sustainable development principle, which we have all signed on to. It has no basis, and Mr Speaker, we need to question them. The Civil Society Organisations (CSOs) need to take this up. Why is it that the Ghana Stabilisation Fund and Ghana Heritage

Fund are being plundered by this Budget? The Minister for Finance is saying that he wants to take the money and spend it now. And look, it is here. On 12th November, they brought this memorandum to Parliament. This year, we all have it. Go into the letterboxes, it is there. They want to change it so that they can spend the money now. The people of Ghana reject that, and this should not be accepted.

Mr Speaker, again, this is a Budget that has no interest in protecting the environment of this country. This Budget has no way of protecting the people of Ghana. In paragraph 1175 of the Budget Statement and Economic Policy, the Minister for Finance made a budgetary allocation of GHC400 million to the waste management sector. Maybe we can say thank you to the President for giving us GHC400 million for waste management treatment. But Kwesi Pratt, in his voice, will say "Mr President, *ye da w'ase, na mmom...*". To wit: However, we want to ask the President how much he has given to the waste management companies to fight waste in this country?

Mr Speaker, let me read a report from professors in Legon: Professor Kwartey, Professor Turkson and Professor Kwame Adjei. In their report titled "*The High Cost of Improper Waste Management and Poor Sanitation in Ghana*", Mr Speaker, they say that poor waste management in Ghana poses a significant public health risk, fuelling outbreaks of sanitation-related diseases like cholera as seen in October. This public health crisis leads to premature

death and increased absenteeism, ultimately hurting productivity and economic production.

Mr Speaker, they continue to say that studies have shown that municipal waste management systems globally contribute over US\$200 billion to every economy. Now, for Ghana, we do not know how much we get. Mr Speaker, interestingly, in the report, it states that the World Health Organisation (WHO) says that if we invest one dollar in waste management, we get five dollars out of it. However, if we look at what we have been doing with our Budget, there is no dedicated fund for waste management treatment. The Sanitation Levy that was introduced has not been repurposed to pay the energy sector debt.

Mr Speaker, we have decided as a country that we do not want to treat waste. As a vice-chair of the Committee on Environment, Science and Technology I find this extremely dangerous that we sit on a time bomb, that our environment is deteriorating, and waste management is not being taken care of. GHC400 million out of a possible GHC1.4 billion is what the President has given to the waste management treatment. I am afraid that if we are not careful this country, an outbreak of cholera will kill the citizens of this country. So we ask ourselves, in whose interest do the President and Dr Ato Forson serve? Do they serve the interests of foreign companies, those in the oil and gas industry, or do they serve the interests of the people of Ghana?

This Budget Statement and Economic Policy, as presented, has no way to help

the people of Ghana. This Budget, as presented, is not helping us to fight the environmental crisis that is upon us. This Budget is empty when it comes to environmental sanitation. GHC400 million will not do a thing. They should not pay everything to the foreign companies.

Mr Second Deputy Speaker: Hon John Darko, wind up please.

1:31 p.m.

Mr Darko: Mr Speaker, I thank you very much for giving me this opportunity, but just to reiterate that we should not allow our money to be repurposed. We should not allow this—

Mr Second Deputy Speaker: Thank you very much. Hon Members, before we take the second round, kindly indulge me to acknowledge our guests at the Public Gallery.

We have Katoma Legacy Academy. They are being led by Mr George Marcus Ashiamah, who is the headteacher. The school is located in the Amasaman Constituency. I hope the Member of Parliament for Amasaman Constituency is here.

[Pupils of Katoma Legacy Academy were acknowledged]

Mr Second Deputy Speaker: The second school is Blessed Adventist Academy. They are being led by Rosemary Dedjoe, who is the from the National Commission for Civic Education (NCCE). The school is located in the Kpone-Katamanso Constituency. I hope

we have the Member here. We also do not have the Member here.

[Pupils of Blessed Adventist Academy were acknowledged]

Mr Second Deputy Speaker: The third group is Ngnomans KKMA JHS Civic Education Club. They are being led by Mr Jones Nana Ketu, who is from NCCE. The school is located in the Kpone-Katamanso Constituency.

[Students of Ngnomans KKMA JHS Civic Education Club were acknowledged]

Mr Second Deputy Speaker: The fourth group is Seduase KKMA JHS Civic Education Club. They are being led by Rita Adjei, who is the Social Studies facilitator. The school, once again, is located in the Kpone-Katamanso Constituency.

[Pupils of Seduase KKMA JHS Civic Education Club were acknowledged]

Mr Second Deputy Speaker: The last group is South Dayi Women's Group. They are being led by Patience Melody Salu, who is the group leader. They are located in South Dayi Constituency. I can see that the Member is cheering the group on.

[Representatives of South Dayi Women's Group was acknowledged]

Mr Second Deputy Speaker: Hon Members, on your behalf, I welcome our guests and wish them well. So, honourable guests, we wish you well. The students among you, we ask you to

study hard so that tomorrow you take our places when we are not here.

Is Hon Collins Adomako-Mensah here? —We will move to Hon Issah Atta. You have 10 minutes. Your time starts now.

STATEMENT

Government's Financial Policy, 2026

[Resumption of commentary from column 8]

Mr Issah Atta (NDC — Sagnarigu): Thank you so much, Mr Speaker. Let me use this opportunity to thank the Minister for Finance for presenting the 2026 Budget Statement and Economic Policy on the theme, "Resetting for Growth, Jobs and Economic Transformation".

Mr Speaker, I want to begin by correcting some erroneous impressions that have been created concerning the investment earnings from our petroleum revenue. Ghana, in the current legislation, has a 1 per cent rate of return on all our petroleum holdings, for example, the Stabilisation Fund and the Heritage Fund. The Ministry of Finance, having talked about the fiscal rigidity that is confronting us as a nation, has decided to diversify the investment portfolio that will generate a total return of 7 per cent. I wonder, in what mindset will they describe 1 per cent as good and 7 per cent as bad?

Mr Speaker, let me begin by highlighting some key strategic visions of the Minister for Finance and the

Government. The total expenditure made by this Government in 2026 is expected to be GH¢302.5 billion, equivalent to about 18.9 per cent of GDP. However, the total projected revenue and grants total an amount of GH¢268.1 billion, that is 18.3 per cent of the prior year's revenue. For the purposes of education, it would be too simplistic to just deduct GH¢302.5 billion from GH¢268.1 billion and claim that is a deficit of Government.

Mr Speaker, let me use this opportunity to provide some indication. We prepare short to medium term expenditure frameworks for every expenditure framework under any economic circumstance. So, the GH¢302.5 billion does not only indicate expenditure for the year 2026. It includes multi-year commitments in the Budget. Mr Speaker, the best measure of fiscal consolidation is the primary balance of commitment basis. This is because the primary balance of commitment basis isolates the independent variable called the interest payments. That is what the Government does not have control over. Dr Ato Forson has achieved 1.6 per cent primary deficit on commitment basis. This means that Government is spending within our means, and that is what we did not see under the eight-year governance of Nana Akufo-Addo.

Mr Speaker, the Budget aligns with Ghana's commitment under the International Monetary Fund (IMF) programme. Balancing stabilisation with productive investment is the goal of this Budget.

Mr Speaker, let me now go to the macroeconomic stability and other micro factors. The 2026 Budget builds on macro stabilisation gains made in 2025, strengthened fiscal discipline, restrained borrowing and improved debt dynamics. As a result of our prudent management of the Ghana economy, where we saw that local treasury bill issues have gone down from 28.9 per cent to about 10.7 per cent. This has made domestic interest debt servicing decline. For instance, if we look at the interest payment projections, they are more manageable and within means. Ministry of Finance has projected interest payment at 57.7 per cent.

If we look at our inflation, people want us to believe that today we should not celebrate inflation of 8 per cent. What it does is that it guarantees confidence in Ghana's economy. Secondly, it allows for people to make proper planning, and thirdly, it does not erode the savings of the ordinary Ghanaian. That is a micro factor that I want my brothers to know. In 2026, the Ministry of Finance projects inflation to still be within the 6 per cent to 10 per cent inflation band.

Let me now come to the growth projections. In March, when I was contributing to the debate, I made it clear that it is not the absolute growth that we are worried about. It is the source of the growth or the drivers of growth. This current growth of 4.8 per cent that is expected at the end of the year is largely driven by manufacturing, industry and agriculture. Mr Speaker, the Budget

prioritises productivity, investment in agriculture, especially the value chain, infrastructure, the roads, the Big Push projects, energy and local enterprises. Reforms in the tax systems are intended to make business and environment more competitive, reducing compliance burden for small, medium scale and incentivise industrialisation.

Mr Speaker, it is important for me to now turn my attention to the external sector performance. As a result of the exchange rate stability —And please, the last time, I heard Hon Kabiru make the assertion that the NDC cannot point to one single thing that led to the debt reduction. We do not need to point to anything. When in doubt, observe the exchange rates. That is a famous quote by H. E. Dr Mahamudu Bawumia. As a result of the management of the exchange rate, the public debt component that is extended and dollar rated, when the cedi is stabilised and reduced, it means that the foreign component will naturally fall. That is what accounts for moving the debt from GH¢726 billion to about GH¢630 billion.

1:41 p.m.

Let me make this statement, Mr Speaker. since the 1950s up to date, before President Akufo-Addo, we have had 13 presidents. They borrowed a total amount of GH¢122 billion. President Akufo-Addo moved from GH¢122 billion to about GH¢726 billion, six times more than all the presidents combined.

Mr Speaker, if you look at the credit ratings, Fitch upgraded Ghana's long-term foreign currency issuer default rating from restricted default to B- with a stable outlook, citing progress of extended debt restructuring, macro-economic stability, and credit policy risk. S&P Global Credit Ratings also upgraded Ghana's ratings to B- with a stable outlook, pointing to improved external balances and stronger policy credibility.

Mr Speaker, I have this to say from the Bloomberg website: the importance of good credit ratings. This is what Bloomberg has to say, that these upgrades are not symbolic; they reflect real improvements in Ghana's external liquidity, its capacity to save debt, and investor confidence.

That is the impact on us. [*Hear! Hear!*]

Mr Speaker, Ghana has successfully restructured about US\$13.1 billion Eurobond debt that they bequeathed to us under the NPP regime. It is important for me to touch on infrastructure. The Minister for Roads and Highways is here, and I am proud to be associated with the NDC Government that is committed to spending GH¢30 billion in the Big Push programme. This would be the largest single-year investment in fiscal infrastructure in recent history.

Mr Speaker, this is not the usual 11,000 km of roads that President Akufo-Addo mentioned here. This infrastructure investment we are seeing is linked

directly to productive sectors. These roads would support agriculture enclave development, regional integration, and trade routes.

Mr Speaker, the agricultural sector, which is the major driver of employment and food security in our country, is expected to be transformed, and the pillar is indicated in the Budget, where we allocated GHC245 million to food security and agro-industrial programmes. Mr Speaker, about GHC828 million for industrial-enclaved roads, about 1,000 km of roads, is expected to improve agriculture. Mr Speaker, GHC690 million to operationalise the Farm Service Centres, which we are proud to initiate and start next year by commissioning the first 50 phase of the farm mechanisation centres.

Mr Speaker, GHC6.9 billion – this is where my interest is – the NPP left this country with a total unemployment of 14.7 per cent. Currently, if you look at the quarterly update from the Ghana Statistical Service (GSS), it is expected that about a 5 per cent reduction in poverty. That is the impact that these programmes are having on our nation.

Mr Speaker, this Budget does not seem to consolidate on only business investment destinations. We are also mindful of the vulnerable. Mr Speaker, let me draw your attention to social investments and safety nets as contained in the Budget. When you look at the livelihood empowerment against poverty (LEAP), a whopping GHC1.1 billion has been allocated to deal with the vulnerable. About GHC401 million has been allocated to the Women's

Development Bank, Apprenticeship, and the rest. I can see my time is running out.

Finally, what I would say is that out-turn is out now. At the beginning of the year, we said we were just doing projections, but now, the out-turn is out. Indicators, pound by pound, 2024-2025, Gross Domestic Product (GDP) growth for 2025 was 5.2 per cent. That was the first two quarters. Currently, we are doing 6.3 per cent. Inflation end year was 23.8 per cent, currently at 8 per cent. Debt-to-GDP ratio of 68.1 per cent, currently 45 per cent. Fiscal deficit of above 3 per cent of GDP, currently 2.8 per cent. Non-oil growth rate, that was 7.8 per cent at their time, and currently we are growing and growing and growing better.

I would end my statement, Mr Speaker, by quoting from a famous playwright, which is, if you watched *Game of Thrones* Grand Maester Pycelle would say, "The small council grows smaller and smaller" —

Mr Second Deputy Speaker: Dr Kabiru Mahama, you are the available Leader. The rules have already been set. I said earlier that I am not going to entertain any interjections. If you think the figures he was churning out is not right, just write it down so that once you or anybody from the Side is speaking, we can flow and get enough time for other things.

Dr Tiah Abdul Kabiru Mahama: Mr Speaker, I am guided and I would take cue from what you said, but when a person's name is mentioned, I think it did not —

Mr Second Deputy Speaker: Dr Mahama, respectfully —

Let me turn to Mr Collins Adomako-Mensah. You are a Deputy Ranking Member, so you have 15 minutes.

Mr Collins Adomako-Mensah (NPP — Afigya Kwabre North): Thank you, Mr Speaker, for the opportunity to comment on the 2026 Budget Statement and Economic Policy as presented by my very good friend, Dr Ato Forson.

Mr Speaker, let me say that I stand here very, very proud as a Member of this particular Caucus, the mighty Minority—*[Hear! Hear!]*—Mr Speaker, for the past one week, we have all had the opportunity to debate this Budget and any objective observer would say that the clarity of thoughts, the depth of knowledge, and the depth of research have been displayed by the Minority. And, Mr Speaker, there is one particular theme that runs through all the debates from our Side; honesty. Members from our Side have been extremely honest with the facts.

Mr Speaker, Members from our Side are even candid enough to acknowledge some good things in this Budget. Unfortunately, I do not see same from our Colleagues from the other Side. All the debates that we have listened to from the Majority Side, none of them, acknowledge the efforts by the Nana Addo Dankwa Akufo-Addo's government. All of them failed to acknowledge any good thing that occurred in our government.

Mr Speaker, a few months ago, we were told that 1,357 containers had vanished from the ports. The issue was debated in this House, and I recall the Majority Leader saying heads must roll. How can containers develop wings? They have all moved away. I remember the Minority Leader advising them that they should take this as an opportunity to embark on major reforms within the energy sector. Mr Speaker, thankfully, the Minister for Energy and Green Transition listened to good advice.

Today, after months of prayers and fasting, the containers have suddenly developed new wings and have flown back to the same port. That is what I am talking about; honesty.

I hear the Minister for Finance, with a very smiley face, talk about increments in revenue in the Electricity Company of Ghana's (ECG) operations. Mr Speaker, that is true. Some increments have occurred. What he failed to say is that that increment is not because of the 10-month operations of ECG. What he failed to tell you, Mr Speaker, is that within the past three years, before the NDC came into power, the reliability improvement project that was begun by the Nana Addo Dankwa Akufo-Addo's government saw to the Bibiani substation constructed, the Daboase substation constructed, the Awaso substation constructed, the Sewua substation constructed, the Tafo Bulk Supply Points (BSP) reconstruction done, the Takoradi port switching substation constructed, the Obuasi BSP substation constructed, and the Kpando substation upgraded.

These are programmes that were embarked upon by the previous government that are yielding results today. Mr Speaker, the Minister failed to acknowledge that the system automation projects that saw to the construction of the Supervisory Control and Data Acquisition (SCADA) system and the Variable Insulation Technology (VIT) centres in Accra, Tema, and Tarkwa were all completed under the Nana Addo Dankwa Akufo-Addo's government.

Mr Speaker, the technical loss reduction programme that was embarked on by the Nana Addo Dankwa Akufo-Addo's government, that led to 1,858 Low Voltage (LV) network extensions completed, 1,345 system improvement projects completed, and 1,347 upgrading of distribution transformers completed. All these things were done under the Nana Addo Dankwa Akufo-Addo government, which is what has led to some of the improvements we are seeing in the energy sector.

1:51 p.m.

Mr Speaker, they fail to acknowledge that the Commercial Improvement Project that led to the Electricity Company of Ghana (ECG) power application (app) improvement—my Brother talked about the *Hubtel* a few months ago. Interestingly, to 1,078,181 smart pre-pay metres installed by the end of 2024. There is nothing wrong in acknowledging the efforts by the previous Administration that is leading to some improvement in revenues.

Mr Speaker, I dare ask, is this US\$90 million revenue even the correct figure? Because the audited financials of ECG is

there for everybody to see. In fact, the US\$1 billion figure that the Minister talked about, was achieved as far back as 2024. In fact, the total revenue of ECG at a close 2024 stood at US\$19.3 billion. A simple calculation will tell us that, the average on a monthly basis was about US\$1.8 billion. So, this is not the first time ECG is recording revenues in the billions.

Mr Speaker, if one increases tariffs close to 18 per cent, what does the expect? What one expects is revenue increase. If we burden the Ghanaian people with a lot more tariffs, we should expect some revenue increment.

Mr Speaker, I want to take us to paragraph 505, it states:

“The Ministry is implementing a national street lighting programme to enhance safety and visibility. Over 1,900 solar streetlights have been installed in the Ashanti Region, with an additional 10,000 smart units to be procured in 2026.”

Mr Speaker, when I saw this, I was a little bit alarmed. Because the Members of the Committee on Energy were informed of this particular programme on the 10th November. I am prepared to turn in this letter in my hand as evidence. This is a letter from the Ministry of Energy and Green Transition, dated 10th November, 2025. The Budget was read on 14th November, 2025. Now this particular letter dated 10th November, was written and addressed to all Regional Ministers. Let me quote the Heading, “Rehabilitation or installation of street lightening systems in regional capitals”.

Mr Speaker, it is very instructive to note on paragraph three. It says:

“as part of the project implementation arrangement, the Ministry will officially launch and hand over the project site to the contractor on Wednesday, November 12th.”

This is very instructive. The letter is dated 10th November, informing Regional Ministers that, this particular programme will be launched on 12th November. Then, the Minister for Finance comes to this House and tells us that, within two days, 1,900 street lights have been installed.

Mr Speaker, I have the official letter. In fact, this letter was informing the regional Ministers of the various contractors on 10th November, 2025 and telling the regional Ministers that the programme that the Minister talked about on the 14th November, 2025, will be launched 12th November, 2025. How a programme that was launched on the 12th November, 2025, necessitate or move to construction of 1,900 street lights in Ashanti Region just beats my imagination.

Mr Speaker, what is even more striking is that in this letter, the quantity to be installed per region is attached; I have it here and he says the Ashanti Region has received 1,900. In the letter from the Ministry to all the various Regional Ministers, Ashanti Region is entitled to only 800. How only 800 suddenly moved to 1,900 within two days, it is only the Minister who can explain to us.

Mr Speaker, I want us to also go to paragraph 507, with your permission, it reads:

“Under the National Electrification Scheme, 117 communities have been connected to the grid, raising national electricity access to 89 percent. Government will expand this coverage through a Turnkey Implementation Model, targeting full national electrification within five years.”

Mr Speaker, this is quoted in the 2026 Budget that the Minister intends to connect 117 communities in order for the electricity access to get to 89 per cent. But ironically, if we turn to the 2025 Budget, paragraph 568, which was presented by the same Minister, with your permission, the Statement reads:

“Mr Speaker, the Ministry of Energy and Green Transition is committed to achieve universal access to electricity. Under the rural electrification programme, a total of 276 communities were connected to the national grid in 2024...”

The phrase in 2024 is the catch word.

“...Increasing the national electricity access rate from 88.95 per cent in 2023 to 89.03 per cent in 2024.”

Mr Speaker, I can say that the figure that the Minister talked about, that they are now going to get to 89 per cent, the Nana Addo Dankwa Akufo-Addo Government, by 2024, had already

reached 89 per cent and I am not the one saying but it is in their own Budget, the 2025 Budget. They had already acknowledged that the Nana Addo Dankwa Akufo-Addo Government had already reached 89 per cent.

In fact, in the 2025 Budget, they promised to move that 89 per cent to 90 per cent, which is the universal access rate. So, they should just acknowledge it. That is why I talked about honesty. They should be candid enough to accept that the Akufo-Addo Government achieved a lot.

Now, Mr Speaker, let me come to the Independent Power Producers (IPP) renegotiations. The Minister talked about some savings within IPP renegotiations; it is interesting. First of all, I want to thank the Minister for now accepting, for now accepting that the contract that they signed between 2012 and 2016 needs some improvements. This is exactly the point we made about take or pay.

Indeed, the Nana Addo Dankwa Akufo-Addo Government was saddled with about US\$600 million a month in debts because of these IPPs. The question is, who would renegotiate a good deal? If it is a good deal, why do you renegotiate? You cannot cause the problem, take plans to reverse it and want us to give you credit for that. It will not happen.

In fact, Mr Speaker, if we look at Cenit, it was signed in 2013, Sunon Asogli, Karpower, 2014. BX Solar,

2014. All these IPPs were signed under their term. If today they want to renegotiate a bad deal, they should just be honest and acknowledge that they did a bad job and they want to reverse it.

Mr Speaker, I want to conclude and say that our Side is not going to be a destructive Minority. We are always prepared to critique when necessary and proffer solutions when necessary. In all these debates, everybody has seen that the mighty and quality Minority—*[Interruption]*—Our job is to see this journey as a Ghana journey and not a National Democratic Congress (NDC) or a New Patriotic Party (NPP) journey.

Mr Speaker, thank you, for the opportunity—*[Hear! Hear]*

Mr Second Deputy Speaker: Hon Members, we will take the third round and thereafter, we will pause and complete the Value Added Tax Bill, 2025, then we come back. That is the agreement we reached here.

So, we would take the third round and I will call on Mr Emmanuel Kwasi Bedzrah. Hon Member, hold on.

Yes, Minority Leader?

2:01 p.m.

Minority Leader (Osahen Alexander Kwamena Afenyo-Markin): Mr Speaker, I was at Conclave and my Hon Colleague has briefed me and like you rightly said, we would have a break and take this VAT Bill.

Mr Speaker, my understanding was that we were going to have some form of winnowing on this VAT in view of some of the issues that cropped up yesterday. I have not seen such move. I do not want us to get there for matters to be raised as if one is obstructing or trying to delay. Sometimes such impression is created and I do not like it. We have been in Government before and our job as Minority is to support Government when it comes to setting key policies for the governance of the country. That we commit. But this VAT Bill in its present form and shape, we would be hurting our country and the business community if we watch unconcerned and say we are going to pass it. Hon Colleagues, no. Let us take our time. My respected Friend, Hon Dafeamekpor has been leading the winnowing.

Mr Speaker, I would want to avail myself and that of my Colleagues, Dr Abdul Kabiru Tiah Mahama, Hon Isaac Boamah-Nyarko and others for us to sit. Hon Deputy Minister for Finance, there is no rush. You have up to the end of December to get your appropriation and other things through. Let us not rush, let us sit down. When you were in opposition, you called for broader consultation and consensus building. It is not a numbers game when it comes to Bills, and you are going to impose tax. So please, let us not rush. Let us consult, discuss and look at the teething issues and not to introduce this and rush it in to say clause 1, clause 2, Third Reading, and get it is passed. We are telling you that it will not pass.

Mr Second Deputy Speaker: Let me listen to the Deputy Minister for Finance.

Deputy Minister for Finance (Mr Thomas Nyarko Ampem) (MP): Mr Speaker, thank you. I appreciate the concern of the Minority Leader, except to let him appreciate the fact that we have consulted widely. In fact, when the Minister for Finance came up with the decision to amend the VAT Act and to actually bring an entirely new Act, we started by consulting stakeholders. We have done a very wide range of consultation. We brought it to the House, it was referred to the Committee and we have dealt with it at the Committee level. There was one issue that he raised yesterday and we thought that we brought finality to it. We are open to other discussions if the Minority wants clearance on some of the issues. But the impression should not be created that we are doing this without consultation and that we are rushing anybody through. We have done thorough work, have engaged a lot of stakeholders, even outside Parliament. So, that impression should not be created at all.

Mr Speaker, thank you.

Osahen Afenyo-Markin: Mr Speaker, with respect, yesterday when the matter was tabled, let me explain something to my respected Colleague from Asuogyaman, Hon Ampem.

Mr Speaker, the Minister for Finance mentioned this in the Budget Statement and Economic Policy and soon thereafter, Papers were laid and referrals made to the Finance Committee. The Finance Committee's Report, when it was ready, the Ranking Member and the Deputy Ranking

Member on the Finance Committee did not even see it. Members on the Minority Side of the Finance Committee did not even see it. The Motion was introduced under certificate of urgency, so where is the consultation?

Now, in the past, Leaders would have the opportunity to peruse such policies, discuss it. Hon Ampem, you said you have consulted and held discussions. I am right here. Tell me in the face whether I ever saw the Bill or even before you laid it, you gave copies to Leadership. I am here. Tell me in the face for *Hansard* to record that I am engaging in mischief.

Mr Speaker, they cannot be introducing Bills and policies under certificate of urgency and expect that we support them. However, if they think they have 189, and would want to use their 189, so be it. They can get their 189 in this Chamber, not less, meet the Constitutional threshold and do what they want to do. Let the people of Ghana see what they are doing. They are imposing new taxes on the people of Ghana under certificate of urgency like they did with the GH¢1.00 per litre, the 18 per cent on electricity tariff, and they expect us to be quiet. We would not be quiet. Our voices will be heard. This is not what they promised the people of Ghana. They promised them that they were not going to impose taxes on them. Live by that promise of principle, not convenience.

Mr Second Deputy Speaker: Thank you. So, we would take the third — Yes, Majority Chief Whip, is it the same

topic? We would go there so let us finish the last batch of —

Mr Dafeamekpor: Mr Speaker, no. These are serious matters.

Mr Second Deputy Speaker: We would get to that point.

Mr Dafeamekpor: Mr Speaker, hear me. I came to meet the Minority Leader in this Chamber; he is senior to me in this Chamber and in Leadership. He knows that at this time of the year, there are many engagements that take place and we do not bring everything to the Floor. So, I respect the views and concerns he is expressing but with all due respect to him, he should not threaten us. He should not say that it would not pass. We want to hear his concerns and factor them into the consideration of the Bill but to say that it will not pass —He should not threaten us. So, he should allow us to engage.

Mr Speaker, with the winnowing, one of the Committees would now consider the matter. So, I am looking for the opportunity so that later today, we can engage at winnowing and deal with the matters. We want to make progress. He just went to do his press conference and we have not responded to his press conference. We are minded to do Business on the Floor. So, he should allow us to make progress. We would take one more commentator on either Side, and then we can deal with the Instruments before us.

Osahen Afenyo-Markin: Mr Speaker, the *avant-garde* of Government Business,

when did he become a diplomat? I do not want diplomacy from him. He is in charge of pound for pound. He should do pound for pound. Why is he being a diplomat? And he is talking about my press conference. When a judge is trying to forcefully remove Hon Matthew Nyindam, the MP for Kpandai. A judge is trying to remove him and we want the nation to know. If you say you would engage on this matter, Hon Ampem will come and sit here to say they have engaged other people. This is the House of Parliament. Even their own Backbench, they have failed to engage them. Look at the empty seats—*[Laughter]*—Look at the empty seats behind them and they come and sit here to say we should pass it.

Mr Speaker, I am not threatening them. I cannot do that. I am only promising them that we will not be part. If you have their 138, they can do it. Well, but it is good the Majority Chief Whip is a diplomat. They are in Government. We are in opposition and we would do our thing. They are in Government and should be diplomats.

Mr Speaker, the man has conceded. We do not need to fight him again. But Hon Ampem should know that they would not take any VAT Bill today. They should know and carry their Backbench along. Carry them; carry Parliament along. There are empty seats behind them. *Me ndi me fie asem?* Really? Minister for Trade, Agribusiness and Industry, have you had your releases for 2025?

Mr Second Deputy Speaker: Yes, Hon Member?

Minister for Trade, Agribusiness and Industry (Ms Elizabeth Ofosu-Adjare) (MP): Mr Speaker, with the greatest of respect, my name has been mentioned.

Mr Speaker, I have been taken care of by the Minister for Finance — *[Uproar]*— I have received my releases, and I am working well, and the Ministry of Trade, Agribusiness and Industry is also doing perfectly well. I have enough money to do my work.

Thank you very much.

2:11 p.m.

Osahen Afenyo-Markin: Mr Speaker, my Colleague is a senior counsel. She has spent many years at the Bar. Her distinguished service is not in doubt. The direct question asked was whether she had received full releases as contained in the 2025 Budget. Having enough money does not mean they have released the money. Does she have her releases?

Mr Second Deputy Speaker: Hon Minister, you have to address the Chair. I have not asked you a question.

Yes, Mr Emmanuel Bedzrah, let us hear you. You have 15 minutes.

Mr Emmanuel Kwasi Bedzrah (NDC — Ho West): Mr Speaker, let me also add my voice to the Budget Statement and Economic Policy, and to commend the Ministry of Finance for bringing a Budget that will reset this economy, bring jobs as well as develop economic transformation.

Mr Speaker, I have been in this House for the past 17 years. This is the first time I have seen a Budget that has been customised; every Member of this House has a budget that has his own name embossed on it. For the newcomers, they have not seen anything yet. This alone tells us that we are resetting and that there is economic transformation in this country, including their own budget.

Mr Speaker, let me correct an impression that was created yesterday, and with your indulgence, I want to state that when the Hon Minority Leader was speaking yesterday, he made an emphatic statement that since 2018, the previous administration has not increased tariffs. He said that this current administration has increased tariffs to the tune of 18 per cent, which was on record yesterday. I want to correct this.

From the Public Utilities Regulatory Commission (PURC) website, it indicated that in 2019, during the multi-year tariff review, an 11.17 per cent increase in tariff for electricity was approved. In the fourth quarter of 2019, 5.9 per cent was approved; in 2023, 27.15 per cent was approved; in the first quarter of 2023, another 29.96 per cent was approved. Then, in the second quarter of 2023, 18.36 per cent was approved; in the third quarter of 2023, 4.22 per cent was approved; in the fourth quarter of 2023, 1.52 per cent was approved; in addition to that, in 2024, 1.4 per cent was approved; in the second quarter of 2024, 3.89 per cent was approved; and in the third quarter of 2024, 3.02 per cent was approved. If we

add all this up, it comes to 120.83 per cent as the electricity tariff that was increased from 2019 to 2024. This cannot be factual —

Mr Second Deputy Speaker: Hon Members, when we laid the ground rules, the Hon Minority Leader was not here. He just came in, and he has been standing throughout. But the ground rules were made clear that we may not allow interjections. So that is why I am begging —

Osahen Afenyo-Markin: Mr Speaker, with respect, ordinarily, if he is rebutting a matter in the public space, that is his right. But he mentioned me specifically and said I had said something.

Mr Speaker, with due deference to Mr Bedzrah, yesterday, my contention was to the effect that in 2018, the Government, through PURC, announced tariff reduction, and that was an *ipso facto* submission I made.

In 2018, if we check on their website, we would find it. In fact, it is contained in their submissions of the Minority to the PURC in the recent engagement we had. We quoted it. In 2018, the Government of Ghana reduced electricity tariffs, ranging from 18 to 30 per cent, and that is what I said. I never said anything about 2019, 2020 and all.

So, if he has his facts on 2019, he can state it. But he should not say I misled the country because I stated what was on public record by PURC. If he wants to quote something else to dispute that, then he can go ahead, but I beg of him, with

the greatest deference, not to misquote me.

Mr Second Deputy Speaker: Mr Bedzrah, you may go on.

Mr Bedzrah: Mr Speaker, the record is there for everybody to listen to. For me, I want to put on record that from 2019 to 2024, the previous administration increased tariffs by 123 per cent.

Mr Speaker, having laid that foundation, I want to state that this current Government has done extremely well when it comes to the power sector as well as the petroleum sector. The power sector, as we all know, was bedevilled with debts, to the tune of US\$1.4 billion, without knowing how this money will be paid. The current administration, through the leadership of the Hon Minister, has paid to the tune of US\$300 million and has negotiated that in 2026, another US\$345 million will be paid. If we do not have an administration or a management of the economy that thinks outside the box, we will not be able to pay for the debts that have accrued. This clearly tells you that the current administration is doing better and far better than any other government.

Mr Speaker, having said that, we all know that power is the engine of growth. Without power, we cannot propel our engine. Without electricity, we cannot expand our economy; without electricity, we cannot even sleep in our rooms because we need electricity to propel it. Having said that, all the Independent Power Producers (IPPs) — my

Colleague mentioned, that there was a renegotiation. Indeed, when one has a leader who understands economics and negotiation, they will negotiate with the producers. So, the current Hon Minister and the Ministry have negotiated through a negotiation team led by Alliance for Social Equity and Public Accountability (ASEPA), no other person but ASEPA, a think tank, to renegotiate the debts, and I can tell them that that renegotiation will give us not less than US\$240 million as surplus. If we had continued in the lane that we were going, we would not have gotten that money into our economy. So, the Hon Minister needs to be applauded for the good work that he is doing; this did not come easy at all.

Mr Speaker, we all know, and we heard from the Public Accounts Committee, how the Electricity Company of Ghana (ECG) has a lot of problems when it comes to the collection of revenue. But the prudent management of ECG, as well as the Ministry of Energy and Green Transition, has helped this country, and today, I can tell you on authority that ECG has increased its revenue from all we know, GHC 900 million, to over GHC1.7 billion. This is what we call “out of the box”. But we know when our Colleagues were there, there were procurement infractions. There were some things that were not supposed to be done, but were done. We all heard all kinds of things that the ECG did at the Public Accounts Committee, all because there was no proper supervision of the ECG. Today, we have proper supervisors of ECG, and they are doing everything in their power to make sure that power stays.

2:21 p.m.

Mr Speaker, when we came to power, at the transition meeting, we were told that if we are not careful, there will be power outages during the year. Today, there is stability of power in this country. That is not all. Apart from the lights being on, there is also—If one is a manager that thinks outside the box, that plans effectively, one will also know that they need to plan for tomorrow. In this Budget, there is going to be a construction of 1,200 megawatts thermal plant—[Hear! Hear!]*—*Why? Because even though we have power that is needed, we have power that will be enough for us, we still need to plan ahead, and in planning ahead, is to start the construction in 2026. This 1,200-megawatts thermal plant will not be only for the country, but it will also be for export purposes.

This, Mr Speaker, resonates with our Budget, that we are resetting for growth, jobs, and economic transformation. If one wants to build a factory in one's constituency or village, as it used to be when we had One Village, One Dam; One District, One Factory, and yet there was no electricity because of *dumsor*, now, because of the excess power, one can build a factory in their village. [Hear! Hear!].

Mr Speaker, when we talk about electricity, as my Colleague has mentioned, we have moved up to about 90 per cent of coverage in this country. In 2026, there will be rural electricity acceleration and urban intensification initiated. Mr Speaker, GH¢2 billion has

been allocated for this phase 1. What will that do? It will expand electricity to every household in this country, every village will have electricity, every community will have electricity. There will not be a community in this country, after 2026, that will not have electricity powering their homes. [Hear! Hear!]

Having said that, Mr Speaker, we all know that our domestic natural gas is expected to reduce our generation cost by 75 per cent. But we saw that this domestic natural gas production will reduce Ghana Gas Company's partnership with other partners. We just had a meeting with them, and we have been told, they have given their full assurance that from next year, there will be Ghana Gas Processing Plant II (GPP II)—[Hear! Hear!]*—*What will that do for us? It will not only add to propel and engineer our thermal plant, but it will also be good for other industrial purposes. Now, this tells us that if one is a planner, an engineer or an economist, one must plan ahead. We sat down in this country without planning, without any additional plans, we were using the old plant, and it was power outage and people could not add to their industry. But we have come, John Dramani Mahama has come, to add to our thermal plant, to make sure that we have additional thermal plant, we have additional gas processing plant, we have excess power in this country which can be exported. **[An Hon Member: Proactive Government]**

Mr Speaker, it is not only the gas processing plant that this administration is thinking of doing. We have also started

a feasibility study of a mini hydro plant in our rivers. These mini hydro plants will also help us in the reduction of our prices. Why do we need to reduce the prices of electricity? We all know that within the subregion, our electricity tariff is the highest. And so, when we have gas on stream, we have thermal and hydro coming on board, the electricity bill will come down, and industries will also be effective.

Having dwelt on the power sector, Mr Speaker, let me move to the petroleum sector. The petroleum sector we all know, has a lot of issues, problems. We initially inherited US\$76.22 per barrel of oil, and that will not help us in this country. The gas price now will be US\$7.53 per MMBTu for the next seven years. And that will give us a total revenue of US\$985 million. If we break it down, we will have US\$190 million for Ghana National Petroleum Corporation (GNPC) and its equity financing, US\$795 million as benchmark revenue, US\$556 million for our Annual Budget Funding Amount (ABFA), which will be used for infrastructure projects, and then additional US\$238 million for our Ghana Petroleum Funds, that is Stabilisation and other funds. This is a prudent management of our natural resources that God has given to this country.

Mr Speaker, in conclusion, let it be known that the policy directives of this Government, the direction that John Dramani Mahama and NDC Government have given investors' confidence to come to this country—*[Hear! Hear!]*—Tullow Oil and its

partners are prepared to sink an additional US\$2 billion. If we did not have a prudent manager, we will not have investors coming. For the past 80 years, we did not have investors coming to invest in this economy. They were rather leaving.

Mr Speaker, I want to announce that this Government will continue to do the right thing, will continue to make sure that ECG through its cash waterfall mechanism will continue to make sure that we have—

Mr Dafeamekpor — *rose* —

Mr Second Deputy Speaker: Thank you so much. It is now the turn—

Yes, Hon Majority Chief Whip?

Mr Dafeamekpor: Mr Speaker, it is now the turn of the third commentator from my Brothers' Side, but the understanding is that we want to seek your leave to curtail the commentaries for now and vary the order of Business to take the Value Added Tax Bill, 2025 at the Consideration Stage.

Alhaji Habib Iddrisu: Yes, Mr Speaker, because we were left with about five or six clauses. So, we just do that, then continue with the debate from this Side.

Mr Second Deputy Speaker: Very well.

Hon Members, let us turn to page 9 of the *Order Paper*, item listed 19, Value Added Tax Bill, 2025 at the Consideration Stage.

Hon Members, I understand yesterday we got to clause 68.

2:31 p.m.

BILL — CONSIDERATION STAGE

Value Added Tax Bill, 2025

[Resumption of Consideration from 25/11/2025]

Clause 68 to 71 ordered to stand part of the Bill.

Clause 72—Interpretation

Mr Second Deputy Speaker: Hon Members, from the Committee, there is no advertised amendment. But I can see the Hon Member for Asante Akim Central.

Mr Kwame Anyimadu-Antwi: Mr Speaker, I do not have anything specific, but to lump everything under Interpretation, which is a lot, I would have thought that the Chairman would go through them one after the other so that we ensure that everything is covered. But if he is satisfied beyond whatever doubt, then we may go ahead.

Mr Second Deputy Speaker: Chairman, did you hear the Senior? He, being the senior legislator, is saying that even though he does not have any issues, he thinks that since there are so many sub-clauses, we could have taken them one by one.

Let me hear from the Chief Whip.

Mr Dafeamekpor: Mr Speaker, Hon Anyimadu-Antwi has been my long-standing Chairperson of the Committee on Constitutional and Legal Affairs, and I served under him. He knows that the practice is that we consider the clauses one after the other, but the Interpretation Clause is one clause, even though it may contain a lot of terms of art that we want to define. So we cannot take the terms as defined one after the other. That is the practice that we adopted in this House.

If he has an issue with one of the interpretations contained in there, he can raise it. But once there is no issue, it has to be taken *en bloc* as one clause.

Mr Second Deputy Speaker: Yes, Alhaji Habib Iddrisu?

Alhaji Habib Iddrisu: Mr Speaker, the Chairperson— *[Expunged by orders of the Speaker]* from the Majority Side—Hon Anyimadu-Antwi is the Chief Whip's senior at the Bar. So if they want us to put it in bulk, we will agree and move ahead. But Majority Chief Whip should stop speaking as if what he is saying is legal, and what Hon Anyimadu-Antwi is saying is not. Hon Anyimadu-Antwi has 15 years more experience at the Bar than him.

Mr Second Deputy Speaker: Yes, Hon Deputy Minister for Finance.

Mr Thomas Nyarko Ampem: Mr Speaker, thank you.

Mr Speaker, the Chairperson of— *[Expunged by the order of the Speaker]* on the other Side just wanted us to hear

his voice. But we started the Consideration yesterday. And even yesterday, because there were no amendments, we thought that those that were short could have been taken together. But we were told that it must strictly go one clause after the other. The Committee has done a good job already. So we believe that we are good to go.

Mr Second Deputy Speaker: Very well.

Clause 72 to 74 ordered to stand part of the Bill.

2:41 p.m.

Clause 75 ordered to stand part of the Bill.

First to Fifth Schedule ordered to stand part of the Bill.

Long title ordered to stand part of the Bill.

Mr Second Deputy Speaker: We have now come to the end of the Consideration Stage.

Mr Dafeamekpor: Mr Speaker, the indication is that we want to take the Motion numbered 20 immediately. That is the Third Reading. Clearly the Minister for Finance is not here, so I want to seek your leave and with the support from the— [Expunged by the order of the Speaker] on the other Side to allow the Deputy Minister for Finance to do this on our behalf. Thank you very much.

Mr Second Deputy Speaker: Hon “Ogunde”, take some of these things lightly—Well, that is true. So, those words should be expunged from the records. I think that is right. We do not have to have this thing in our records.

Mr Dafeamekpor: Mr Speaker, where was “Ogunde” when my Brother referred to me as the— [Expunged by order of the Speaker]

Mr Second Deputy Speaker: The directive is that all those words be expunged. Including the one which was said to you.

Mr Dafeamekpor: No, but Mr Speaker, that is the cliché for the Whips. It is not unparliamentary. It is actually a parliamentary term for the Whips. So, when Hon Habib said so, he said so in context. I did not take any offence. We refer to each other convivially so. It is a convivial term that we use, so it is fine.

Mr Second Deputy Speaker: The directive has already been given. Let us take them out of the records.

Alhaji Habib Iddrisu: Mr Speaker, we do not have any problem with Motion numbered 20 being moved, except that the Majority Chief Whip did not tell us the whereabouts of the Minister and why the Deputy Minister needs to do so. Mr Speaker, the Minister is imposing taxes, and he is going to collect money from people. Why is it that he is not in the Chamber and wants his Deputy to move it? So, the Majority Chief Whip must give a better explanation as to the whereabouts of the Minister when he

wants to put a burden on Ghanaians. We will not allow the Deputy Minister to do it.

Mr Dafeamekpor: Mr Speaker, the Constitution defines a Deputy Minister as Minister of State. My Brother knows that originally the Leaders were to have concluded the debate this afternoon, so the Minister for Finance has been preparing to come and give his concluding remarks when they do so. But because of the change in time, he had to adjust some other meetings. So, he will be here. He has been a Leader of this House, and he is a Member of the House. So far, the Businesses have been ably conducted by his Deputy. I do not think there is a problem. Hon Habib just wants to be—I fear to use that term because he will litigate it further. So, he should permit the Deputy to take this one on his behalf.

We welcome the Minority Leader.

Mr Second Deputy Speaker: Hon Deputy Minister, the leave is granted.

Ahaji Habib Iddrisu: Mr Speaker, the Majority Chief Whip is of the view that the Deputy Minister is a Minister of State. Let us check the *Order Paper* for today. It says “Minister for Finance” it does not say “Deputy Minister for Finance”. So, if he is making an application for us to agree, he should do so, but he should not say it is within their rights.

Mr Second Deputy Speaker: So, Deputy Minister—

Osahen Alexander Kwamena Afenyo-Markin: Mr Speaker, we agreed that we will allow the clause-by-clause consideration of the Bill. I want to act by what we have all agreed upon. Let us have the 48-hour rule and then do the Third Reading. We cannot be doing this to ourselves. Please, Hon Colleagues, we have not even closed the debate. There is no rush. Take it easy. We have today—

Mr Second Deputy Speaker: Hon Leader, not to cut you short, but the Motion that we are taking is not the Value Added Tax Bill, 2025 which has just been—

Osahen Afenyo-Markin: No, Mr Speaker, I am reminding them. It is something that was just whispered to me. That is why I am letting him know that he should not contemplate it because that is not the understanding we have. Please, the way every now and then there is a certificate of urgency with no scrutiny, it has serious implications.

Mr Second Deputy Speaker: Leader, normally financial Bills are always taken under the certificate of urgency?

2:51 p.m.

Osahen Afenyo-Markin: Mr Speaker, I am aware and have seen it, but it does not take away the obligation on us under Order 104.

Mr Speaker, it does not take away the provisions in Order 104. If the certificate of urgency rule is being invoked, what is triggering that? We are considering the

Budget. The Minister for Finance has come and said we should run this through. We said alright. At least we finished all the clauses.

We are still debating the 2026 Budget Statement and Economic Policy, and it is not as if we are done with the approval of the economic policy, and then estimates are done, and there is a need to quickly deal with it. No. Mr Speaker, we should invoke that rule sparingly. Let me read Order 104. They cannot move that Motion today for Third Reading. They cannot have the Third Reading today. Mr Speaker, we must not encourage it. Mr Speaker, you are the presiding officer. We are debating the 2026 Budget Statement and Economic Policy. We have not even gone to the Estimates.

Mr Speaker, why would we have to rush? Why would we have to rush to suspend the Orders and take the Third Reading today? It is a financial Bill that is why we have run it through, and the winnowing was not done. So why do we have to rush it?

Mr Dafeamekpor: Mr Speaker, I know the Minority Leader very well because in my formative years, he taught me a couple of things. He is just filibustering. The rule that he cited and failed to read does not support the position he is canvassing. It does not. So, nothing stops this House from taking Motion numbered 20. Yes, I agree that we build consensus on these things; we do not litigate everything. If he thinks that we have other businesses to consider, so we should take this later in the day or tomorrow, he should say so.

But he should not—because when he was at the Majority Side, just a year ago, the kind of Instruments that we took under certificate of urgency, during an election year—he was here. This was his seat, and we supported him. So, he left this seat barely a year ago.

Mr Second Deputy Speaker: Let us hold on with this and just reach out, please.

Mr Dafeamekpor: I would engage him, and then we can agree on when to take this but he should stop intimidating me, because he cannot. We are building consensus.

Mr Speaker, I thank you.

Osahen Afenyo-Markin: Mr Speaker, Order 104(1) provides:

“Except as provided in rule (2) of this Order, a Motion shall not be debated until at least two sitting days have elapsed after the notice is given.”

Why does he invoke Order 104? It says that except—when there is a Motion before the House, it takes 48 hours after it has been laid. Is that not the rule? Do they not come for a waiver under certain conditions, that it is urgent to waive the 48-hour rule? Third Reading requires at least 48 hours. True or false?

Mr Speaker, he has already considered that he would defer. He would not take Motion numbered 20. He says we should engage; therefore, I would avail myself.

Mr Second Deputy Speaker: Yes, just engage.

Mr Dafeamekpor: Mr Speaker, let the record refer that this is a procedural Motion, not a substantive Motion.

Mr Second Deputy Speaker: My order is to engage, so please engage.

Mr Dafeamekpor: Yes, we would engage.

Alhaji Habib Iddrisu: Mr Speaker, now we can come back to the commentary on the Budget.

Mr Dafeamekpor: Mr Speaker, we would go back to Motion numbered 8(a) and take one Member from each Side, and then we would come back to the Instruments. Then we would come back to it.

Mr Second Deputy Speaker: We would take two Members from the Minority Side, then one Member from the Majority Side.

Mr Dafeamekpor: Mr Speaker, agreed but we would leave the formulas in your hands.

Mr Second Deputy Speaker: So, Hon Deputy Leader, are you ready to have a bite today?

Alhaji Habib Iddrisu: Mr Speaker, since you are going to take two Members from the Minority side, and one from the Majority Side, if we can go to Ms Ida Asiedu and then another Member from the Majority Side, then our able Minority

Deputy Leader would have her 30 minutes to expose some of the wrongs in the Budget.

Mr Second Deputy Speaker: Yes. Ms Ida Adjoa Asiedu? It appears she is not ready for the commentary. Are you ready for the commentary?

Ms Ida Adjoa Asiedu: Yes.

Mr Second Deputy Speaker: All right, let us hear you. You have 10 minutes.

STATEMENT

Government's Financial Policy, 2026

[Resumption of Commentary from Column 26]

Ms Ida Adjoa Asiedu (NPP — Ayensuano): Thank you, Mr Speaker, for the opportunity given to me to participate in the debate of the 2026 Budget Statement and Economic Policy by the President. Mr Speaker, my focus today is on one pillar that undergirds true transformation, that is human rights allocation. These are not mere line items; they are the lifeblood of our democracy, enshrined in articles 12 to 33 of our 1992 Constitution: The African Charter on Human Rights and Peoples' Rights and the Universal Declaration of Human Rights.

Mr Speaker, the NPP has long championed gender equity for our Affirmative Action (Gender Equity) Act, 2024 that laid the groundwork for women's leadership, to our investment in

action, skills, and financial inclusion that empower rural women in constituencies like mine. Yet, this Budget, Mr Speaker, while claiming a gender-responsive mantle, reveals a pattern of a modest increment that falls short of transformational action. Mr Speaker, this is not surprising because while President Mahama promised 30 per cent appointments to women during his campaign, he is currently falling short at only 23.21 per cent.

Mr Speaker, in his maiden State of the Nation's Address in February this year, President John Dramani Mahama again promised to establish the Women's Development Bank as part of his 120-day social contract to empower women economically by providing low-interest loans for women-owned small enterprises.

Mr Speaker, the 2025 Budget Statements and Economic Policy promised GHC51 million allocation of seed money towards the establishment of the bank. Mr Speaker, the women of Ghana want to know the state of the Women's Development Bank nine months down the line. Yet, the 2026 Budget Statement and Economic Policy also allocated an additional GHC400 million to the Women's Development Bank. On paper, it looks so beautiful and great. Mr Speaker, but we await how its implementation would turn out.

3:01 p.m.

Mr Speaker, let us scrutinise the allocation for women and girls, comparing them starkly to 2025 to

expose the gap between rhetoric and reality.

Mr Speaker, on menstrual hygiene, a fundamental right that keeps our girls in school and out of poverty, the allocation remains stagnant at GHC292.4 million, unchanged from 2025.

In 2025, this funding was used to distribute sanitary pads to 1.6 million girls in basic schools. Our girls deserve better, more than recycling funds. The 2026 allocation should be scaled up and the policy extended to cover our girls at the secondary school level to eradicate period poverty nationwide—*[Hear! Hear!]*

Mr Speaker, let us now turn the attention of this House to the most shameful line item in this entire Budget, the domestic violence fund. This Government has increased the allocation from a pathetic GHC337,500,000 to GHC1 million. On paper, it looks progressive but in reality, it is an insult wrapped in statistics. *[Hear! Hear!]*

It is an insult to every woman who has been beaten, raped, acid-burned, psychologically tortured, economically starved or killed in their own homes. Mr Speaker, GHC 1 million for a country? An amount of GHC1 million when Domestic Violent and Victims Support Unit (DOVVSU) alone recorded 14,000 plus domestic violence cases in 2024, and the trend is rising? One single 30-bed shelter costs between GHC8 million to GHC12 million to build — Mr Speaker, do the mathematics with me; GHC1 million divided by 14,000—*[Interruption]*—

Mr Second Deputy Speaker: Order!
Order!

Ms Asiedu: Mr Speaker, GH¢ 1 million Ghana divided by 14,000 reported cases, would give you GH¢71 per victim—*[Interruption]*—Mr Speaker, GH¢71 to cover emergency medical bills, temporary shelter, transport, legal aid, trauma counselling and child support. Mr Speaker, GH¢71, to tell a woman whose jaw has been broken that the Government values her life less than a bag of cement.

Mr Speaker, let us be clear. Reported cases are only a tip of the iceberg. In 2023, Ghana Statistical Service data showed 71 per cent sexual violence survivors never report. The real number is probably about 50,000 serious cases per year. That brings the value this Government has placed on each battered woman to GH¢20. It is less than an *olonka* of *gari*—*[Interruption]*—

Mr Speaker, this is not funding. This is a performance curiosity dressed in compassion. We in the super Minority call for a GH¢50 million annual domestic violence and a victim support fund, enough for 10 fully equipped shelters, a nationwide 24-hour toll-free crisis line with real follow-up, specialised courts, victim rehabilitation programmes, nationwide public education and a proper gender-based violence data system.

Mr Speaker, this GH¢1 million is not a prioritisation when little girls in the north are being married off and

brutalised. When university students are being raped at campuses, and when market women are being beaten for disagreeing with their husbands—*[Interruption]*—and the national response is GH¢1 million? By this, we are telling the perpetrators to go on, because the nation or the state will look somewhere. —*[Hear! Hear!]*—This is not a Budget item and it should not be accepted. We demand an upward adjustment in increased direct victim support—*[Hear! Hear!]*—provided shelters, specialised prosecution units and public education. Anything less is a betrayal of our mothers, sisters, daughters and our own mother Ghana. *[Hear! Hear!]*

Mr Second Deputy Speaker: Thank you.

Hon Members, Order! Order!

Hon Members, it is now the turn of Mr Simon Kyeremeh Ampaabeng. Hon Member, you respectfully have ten minutes.

Mr Simon Ampaabeng Kyeremeh (NDC — Berekum East): Mr Speaker, thank you very much for indulging me and giving me the opportunity to contribute to the Budget Statement and Economic Policy of Government for the 2026 financial year.

Mr Speaker, I want to thank His Excellency, the nation builder, Mr John Dramani Mahama, for such an incredible performance within the space of 11 months under his leadership. I am so much impressed.

Mr Speaker, some of us had a lot of belief, confidence and trust in him to deliver and to clean the mess of the NPP, Akufo-Addo/Bawumia Administration. However, the speed of light with which he is cleaning the mess is so admirable.

Mr Speaker, let me also thank the Minister for Finance, Dr Cassiel Ato Forson, for the wonderful presentation on the 13th November, 2026, pursuant to Article 79 of the Constitution. At least, for now, we have a Minister for Finance who will not only come here to arouse our emotions about the problem that surrounds us and give rhetorics in theory. But now we have a PhD holder, who links academic knowledge in theory to national development in practice—*[Hear! Hear!]*—and today, we are feeling the doctorate degree he holds. Indeed, Ato you are forcing.

Mr Speaker, there is one thing that is so dear to the heart of every Ghanaian, irrespective of wherever one finds themselves, being a teacher, a farmer or whoever. That is the rate at which the price of goods and services increases.

We were in this country, when my Colleagues on the other Side had the opportunity—full 90 minutes on the park and they could not even score one goal—*[Interruption]*—with even extra time.

3:11 p.m.

Inflation increased under their watch to over 54 per cent, and at the end of year inflation at 23 per cent. Just in 10 months, His Excellency John Dramani

Mahama, the nation builder, has reversed it to a single digit, 8 per cent, and what are my Colleagues on the other Side saying? When we were leaving power in 2016, we handed over the Ghana cedi at US\$1 to GH¢4. Just in 8 years, they took it to US\$ 1 to GH¢16, and today, it is at US\$ 1 to GH¢11, and my what are my Colleagues on the other Side saying?

Mr Speaker, the people in the market and the business community, are happy, because, hitherto, a businessman who would require US\$100,000 to do imports, will have to organise at least 1.6 billion old cedis but today, the same investor or importer, will require just about 1.1 billion old cedis with the savings of about GH¢50,000, and you say the business people are not happy? What are they talking about?

Mr Speaker, for the past one week, I have been listening to my Colleagues in amusement, and I wonder how they argue with such level of confidence. It is so surprising because we were in this country, when over GH¢400 million, was used to dig a hole, in the name of a cathedral, and they are talking about unemployment, do they have an idea as to how that money could have been translated into job creation for the young people of this country, and they sit here to say what? We were in this country, when we were recording one week, one scandal, they think we have forgotten. They took the price of fuel to about GH¢16.00 per litre, today, in spite of everything, we still have it at GH¢11 per litre. Initially, I was buying about GH¢2,500 in and out from here to Berekum, my Constituency. But as we

Speak, just about GH¢1,800 could take me to Berekum and back to Accra, and they think I am not happy? Do they think the drivers and the passengers are not happy? What are they saying?

Mr Speaker, we were all in this country since Ghana became Ghana, up to President Akufo-Addo, Ghana had a debt of GH¢122 billion, just in eight years, they took it to GH¢726 billion. Even when they said they were doing better, they left us a debt to GDP by close of year 2024, about 61 per cent, just in 10 months. The nation builder, John Dramani Mahama, has dropped it down to 45 per cent, and still going down. We are so optimistic and happy, and we believe that this country can only get better under the tenure of John Dramani Mahama. We are very optimistic about that.

Mr Speaker, we were in this country when our Colleagues came to Parliament and told us that they had constructed about 11,000 kilometres. In fact, I do not know where those roads were. But as we speak, there is a single investment of an expressway to be constructed from Accra to Kumasi, and some of us will use that road. It will be the only expressway from Accra to Kumasi, a modern six-lane bidirectional expressway, and this alone is going to create about 490,000 jobs, and they say they do not like this, what do they want?

Mr Speaker, some of us who are on this Side — I have always been praying that we will get a visionary leader who will not only come and spend our money anyhow, but will invest into the roads

and the infrastructure of this country, and anybody in this country who will be forthright and honest, will attest to the fact that when it comes to infrastructure, President John Dramani Mahama has no classmate. I was not surprised when the nation builder, through Dr. Cassiel Ato Forson presented in the Budget Statement and Economic Policy, the Big Push, and as we speak, our Region has gotten a fair share, and I believe their Regions have also received, so they have nothing to do than to applaud the President for such a wonderful job. When we are able to finish the expressway, at least some of us who travel back to our constituencies every weekend will only use two hours from Kumasi to Accra. My brother, *wo mpe wei na wo pe den?* To wit, if you do not like this, what do they want?

Mr Speaker, His Excellency John Dramani Mahama, the nation builder, is doing so well, and when one takes their time to read this Budget Statement and Economic Policy, paragraph by paragraph, one has no option than to say a prayer for His Excellency John Dramani Mahama to implement at least 60 to 70 per cent of all that we have in this Budget Statement and Economic Policy and Ghana will be a good place for all of us to live. In terms of jobs, very clear categorical policies and avenues to create jobs have been provided.

Mr Speaker, in conclusion, when I listen to my Colleagues on the other Side, I become so surprised about their level of confidence. We were in this country, when Ghanaians showed them —

Mr Second Deputy Speaker: Thank you. It is now the turn of—[*Uproar*]

Mr Ampaabeng Kyeremeh: Mr Speaker, thank you for giving me the opportunity—[*Hear! Hear!*].

Mr Second Deputy Speaker: Yesterday we listened to the Deputy Majority Leader and today we are going to listen to the Deputy Minority Leader — [*Hear! Hear!*]. So, Hon Leader, you have 30 minutes. If it is too much, you can lend me some.

Deputy Minority Leader (Ms Patricia Appiagyei) (NPP — Asokwa): Mr Speaker, thank you. I know my Friends from the other Side are going to listen attentively for what I have to say on the Budget Statement and Economic Policy authorised by His Excellency the President John Dramani Mahama and presented by our Hon Minister for Finance, Cassiel Ato Baah Forson.

Mr Speaker, since we started this commentary, I have been quietly sitting and listening to all the commentaries that are coming on the Floor of this House and my impression about the commentaries coming from the opposite Side, that is our Majority Side of the House, is one of lamentation. I was really surprised when a contributor yesterday mentioned that we have to create a lamentation book.

3:21 p.m.

It is very interesting in the sense that from the first day the Budget Statement

and Economic Policy was presented, we did not have any other comment but to let them know that the entire Budget is full of lamentations; issues that have long passed. The previous government is gone, and a new government is in place. We are one year down the line, and a Budget has been drawn; we are doing another Budget, yet what are we experiencing? The contributions that are coming from the other Side are only full of lamentations of what has long gone. They have taken the mantle. What we expect from them is to fix everything that they think is wrong. What are we talking about?

Mr Speaker, yesterday, I was very happy when an Hon Member also contributed and mentioned that their first year was a correction year. For me, it is an admonition that they have realised that they did not do anything concerning your policies; Nothing. They did not deliver anything in their first year, and they are expecting that in their second year, something good will come out of it. This now brings us back to the 2026 Budget.

Mr Speaker, I find it deeply concerning that earlier contributions that we have listened to have ignored the issue of gender. If I am talking about gender, I am not only concentrating on both males and females. My concern is about the female aspect of the Budget. It is interesting that at a time when the Government speaks boldly of resetting for growth, jobs and economic transformation, I see no solid foundation to support this ambition. Why do I say this?

They have all manner of projects, which they believe would create jobs, but there is no gender aggregation of how they would do those projects. How can they then rise up and say that the Budget is gender sensitive? I will give them a typical example of what I mean by evidence-based budgeting. In 2025, when they wanted to address the issue of sanitary pads to encourage more girls to go to school, they were able to identify 1.3 million girls whom they would distribute sanitary pads to. It is specific, and what we need to interrogate now is whether they were able to even service those 1.3 million girls. But I am happy to note that instead of accounting for that number, the only mention of the sanitary pad in the Budget is that 6.6 million packets of sanitary pads have been purchased. What has been the impact? Were they able to distribute to 1.3 million girls?

One of the other issues I want to raise concerning this particular provision is that there is a mention that this time around, they would add on to the Senior High School girls, but does the 1.3 million girls include them? So, what is this position now? And that is the question I raised. Were they able to supply the 1.3 million girls? I see that it has been conveniently avoided. But they are accountable to us in this House to ensure that what was said is working.

Mr Speaker, there is another issue about these sanitary pads—

Dr Clement Abas Apaak — *rose* —

Mr Second Deputy Speaker: Hon Deputy Minister, respectfully, we have set the grounds rules. Afterward, you would get the opportunity, and if there is something you think needs to be corrected, you can do so.

Hon Minority Deputy Leader, you may continue.

Ms Appiagyei: Mr Speaker, in the 2026 Budget, the only mention of a figure is the GH¢6.6 million, and I have also taken note that the same budgetary allocation that was given in 2025 has been repeated in the 2026 Budget. What are we trying to say? Once they have mentioned that they are now going to add the Senior High School Education, how are we to digress this? What is at stake? Is there a need to funding balance they need to introduce before they can add on the SHS students? Or we take it that what has been reported to be GH¢6.6 million, for which the cost was GH¢292.4 million, is the absolute that can cater for all the girls in both basic and SHS?

Mr Speaker, another issue about the sanitary pad is that I want to let them know that when the issue of pricing was raised on this floor, I could not really understand what the issues were. So, I had to go to the market myself to go and find out what the prices are. We are looking at a pack of 12, and if I do my mathematics well, it still gives me the figure of GH¢45 per pack. I want the Hon Minister to confirm. This sanitary pad is a pack of 12 pieces. Can this pack of sanitary pads be sold for GH¢45? This is one of the sanitary pads that were distributed. That is another one, and they

all portray different prices far below the GH¢45 that we were talking about.

So, there are different types of sanitary pads, and they are all below the GH¢20.

[The Hon Member displayed the sanitary pad]

So, as I indicated, we could not really get the import of what has been reported to us, that GH¢292.4 million has been spent on 6.6 million sanitary pads.

Mr Speaker, in our submission, I also heard a comment that we on the Minority Side are not in favour of the distribution of the sanitary pads. That is totally incorrect. I want to state it here and now that we all advocated for the distribution of the sanitary pads, but another concern is the fact that when schools were reopening for the new semester, in addition to the prospectus that was given to the SHS, it contained the need for parents to buy those sanitary pads to cater to them.

3:31 p.m.

Mr Speaker, we are here to support a worthy cause and we believe that it is important that if we want to implement this programme well, it is for the good of the people of this country. We are all representatives of the people in Ghana and I would like to implore each one of us that the implementation of the distribution of sanitary pad must be done and done well.

Mr Speaker, one other issue about gender is that women are about 52 per cent of our population, and we have it on

record. Yet the Budget fails to reflect any meaningful gender- sensitive analysis. It is important that all the programmes that were mentioned and being promoted out there, I repeat, that must be—

Mr Dafeamekpor — *rose* —

Mr Second Deputy Speaker: Hon Majority Chief Whip, Hon Members, respectfully, we have set the grounds rules. I have already indicated to him that I am not allowing that. So, after the Hon Deputy Minority Leader has spoken, we will find a way, if there is any correction—But to interject, I will not allow that.

So, Hon Deputy Minority Leader, you may proceed.

Ms Appiagyei: Mr Speaker, that was a contribution from our Side of the House. It was not to discourage the programme, but the suggestion was to seek the possibility of manufacturing these sanitary pads whereby the Government could introduce on a regional basis, an industry, considering the large sums of money that is going to be applied to it. It can be introduced on a regional basis and create more jobs, which will be very obvious to everybody, the job creation that they are talking about.

Many of the initiatives mentioned sound good on paper, Mr Speaker, but they are not evidence based. I do not see anywhere in the 2026 Budget, a clear articulation of how the programmes would directly impact the lives of the women whom I have been advocating

for. If this House is to approve this programme, then we must insist on specificity. The Budget must provide the actual numbers; the number of women that are going to benefit from all these programmes. Mr Speaker, you will agree with me that if we want economic growth, women cannot be left out of it. There should be a conscious and deliberate effort to ensure that whatever programmes we are churning out; women will be the major beneficiaries of those programmes.

Mr Speaker, I cannot simply allow programmes to be listed without evidence. The clarity of numbers and gender disaggregation data must guide how we project growth and how we evaluate its effect on women. There is a clear failure by this Government to neglect the gender budgeting, and it is a big risk. It is violating the Canadian International Development Agency (CIDA) commitments and the commitment by the NDC to achieve 30 per cent women representation target by 2026. How many Cabinet Ministers do we have, and how many are women? How many are appointees?

Mr Speaker, it is interesting to note that Ghanaians have had high expectations of us politicians, especially the NDC, having come out to appoint a first woman Vice President. It was everybody's expectation that by now, we should have started implementing the Affirmative Action (Gender Equity) Act, 2024 (Act 1121). If we look at page 1 of the *Order Paper*, the item numbered 4, among the Bills that have to be

presented, what am I seeing? There is a clear evidence or absence of the regulatory framework that will be required to implement the Affirmative Action (Gender Equity) Act, 2024. What has happened to it? One year down the line, we do not know where we are going. It is the expectation of Ghanaians, because they have shown the light and we were expecting that they are definitely going to do something about it. We need to ensure that whatever they promise does not become a failure.

It was noted in the 2025 Budget that GH¢51 million have been assigned for the women's bank. Now, we are adding on GH¢401million. What we need to know is that was the money disbursed? What are we going to do to implement, because we do not have any guidelines as to how to implement those moneys. They have actually been allocated, but without any guidelines for its implementation.

Mr Speaker, you would remember that there are so many programmes, policies, when mentioned, can be described as good policies, but the implementation alone can turn them into bad policies. So, I do not see why they should be up, hailing and clapping because of programmes that do not even have the basis for implementation. A modern budget must present a gender-tagged results framework, beneficiaries expected outcomes, regional targeting and indicators. This Budget does not meet that. Ghana cannot claim to be serious about inclusiveness of women's economic participation that appears only as a paragraph in a long document.

3:41 p.m.

Mr Speaker, it is important that as we stand here and present our Budget, we turn to the matter that affects the dignity of education and well-being of millions of girls. I am emphasising again that the free sanitary pad initiative is a programme that must be done and done well. So, what I expect from us is to come up with clear guidelines and figures. I want us to invite the Ministry here to give us a good account of the expenditure of the GH¢292 million. If GH¢292 was not enough in the 2025 Budget, why is the same amount being allocated?

Mr Speaker, I would like to plead with you to take note of that, and that answer must be solicited from the implementers of that programme. Is the Government planning to cut the programme? Or were the earlier figures inflated to justify excessive expenditure?

Mr Speaker, I am moving on to the amount of GH¢452 million from last year 2025 to next year 2026. I want to ask, if the private sector is leading the initiative, what is the GH¢110 million doing? I am talking about the 24-Hour Economy. Which sectors does it target? Who are the expected beneficiaries? Is it for the private sector?

Then I go straight to unemployment. Mr Speaker, recent reports indicate that 70,000 trained nurses, midwives, laboratory technicians and other health professionals remain unemployed after completing state-regulated training. Yesterday, the Minister for Health was

around to inform us that he is only going to employ 15,000 people. What is going to happen to our nurses? I intend to bring our attention to when a contributor mentioned that they are building Community Health and Planning Services (CHPS) compounds in every district, metropolitan and municipal assembly. Ultimately, we are going to have 276 CHPS compounds. Who are the staff who are going to be engaged to do that? Because we are at a time when the CHPS compounds are understaffed, and district hospitals are operating below capacity.

Let us also look at the issue of allocating billions to flagship promises and politically convenient programmes. Then surely, we can allocate space in the Budget to employ nurses and midwives whose skills shall save lives. It is important that this issue is brought to the fore for a general discussion. What have nurses done to this Government for them to be trained and be left alone? What have nurses done to this Government? It is important that we look at the avenues of doing that. They have only allocated GH¢100 million to support the Agenda 111 hospital projects, but they have not trained nurses. They want them to fly off to other places. So, what have the nurses done? What have the teachers done to this Government that they are not being taken care of? And there are no provisions for them to be absorbed into the system to work. What have they done?

We must know that something will be done about the 70,000 people. If they are not going to be able to absorb 70,000

people, where are they creating 800,000 jobs? Is it a sin to be a teacher or a nurse? Why are they ignoring this group of people? We must ensure that they pay attention to them. Because a good chunk of money has been spent to train them. And it is important that these people are given the necessary attention and employment they need. What have teachers and nurses done to our Minister for Finance for not making the right provision for them to be absorbed into the system?

Mr Second Deputy Speaker: Hon Leader, be winding up.

Ms Appiagyei: Mr Speaker, the fundamental question Ghanaians continue to ask is simple. Where are the jobs? They promised the youth of this country. Let us be specific. How many jobs have been created under the 24-Hour Economy? How many jobs have been created through the National Coders Programme? *[Hear! Hear!]*

Mr Second Deputy Speaker: Thank you. Yes, Leader?

Mr Dafeamekpor: Mr Speaker, as you directed, Dr Apaak, Deputy Minister for Education, wants an opportunity to correct one or two information put out by the Deputy Minority Leader.

Mr Second Deputy Speaker: Hon Leader, I guess Dr Clement Apaak has not taken his turn. Has he taken his turn?

Mr Dafeamekpor: No, but he is not commenting today. Today is the last day for Hon Members.

Mr Second Deputy Speaker: That is all right. He should take note. Please, we set the ground rules for everyone.

3:51 p.m.

Mr Dafeamekpor: Mr Speaker, at Plenary yesterday, we set out some guidelines to moderate the debate and the commentary, I should say. But it is also our rule that where the comments breach Order 122, it is permissible for a Member to interrupt the comments and to set the matters aright. Instead of interrupting, you directed that if he is so-minded, he should note down the issues, so that when the Hon Deputy Minority Leader was done, then he could be given some minutes to set the issues. That is what we do.

Mr Second Deputy Speaker: Hon Leader, I have to be straightforward and principled on this. I have not allowed anybody to speak. My Friend, Hon Clement Apaak knows that if there is an opportunity, I will give him. So, Hon Clement Apaak, just dot whatever mistakes you think the Deputy Leader just came up with. You get opportunity, then you address it. I want the commentary to be flowing. It will limit the time we waste, because somebody will be interjecting, another one will interject. At least, today, the debate has flowed? So, please, Hon Clement Apaak, just bear with me. I would not allow any interjections. So, if he is debating, we will allow that.

Mr Dafeamekpor: Mr Speaker, I indicated that he is not among those who will comment on the Statement today.

Mr Second Deputy Speaker: Then tomorrow, it should be.

Mr Dafeamekpor: Mr Speaker, tomorrow, the Leaders are concluding—*[Uproar]*—So, our rules permit—

Mr Second Deputy Speaker: Leader, then why can he not pass it on to the next person who is coming to—it is the same. Just pass it on to someone who is—

Mr Dafeamekpor: Our next commentator, so Dr Apaak should debate.

Mr Second Deputy Speaker: So, Dr Apaak can debate. Thank you. His name is not here. Hon Members, if his name is not here, it means one person is already automatically gone.

Dr Clement Abas Apaak (NDC — Builsa South): Thank you, Mr Speaker—

Mr Second Deputy Speaker: Hon Clement, hold on.

Mr Patrick Yaw Boamah: Thank you, Mr Speaker, we know for a fact that Dr Apaak is not listed to speak today. If that application has been made by the Majority Chief Whip, then you should be notified as to whose name you are deleting from the list before you. It has to be clear. We do not want anything—

Mr Second Deputy Speaker: Today, nine Members on each Side are commenting.

Mr Dafeamekpor: Mr Speaker, I prayed that you permit Dr Apaak to

comment on the Statement with your leave. You indicated that if he were so minded, then he could comment today, when clearly tomorrow, he will not have the opportunity. So, I took advantage of that and asked that he should be permitted to comment. Why should this generate—

Mr Second Deputy Speaker: Hon Members, I do not think we need to split hairs on this. Today, we have nine on each Side. So, now that Hon Clement Apaak has come in, the ninth person is automatically off. The ninth person is Hon Dickson Kyere-Duah, according to the list they provided.

Osahen Afenyo-Markin: Mr Speaker, there was an agreement, and the agreement was that the Deputy Minority will close the day. It was left with one Member from the opposite Side and two from here. The Hon Majority Chief Whip should not introduce anything new. When I was leaving the Chamber, the understanding was that there was going to be one on their Side, we come back and Deputy Minority Leader will finish. That is why Hon Habib Iddrisu made the application for Deputy Minority Leader to hold on for a Colleague to comment before because she is a Leader.

Mr Second Deputy Speaker: Leader, that is right.

Osahen Afenyo-Markin: Therefore, that ends the matter. There can be another opportunity.

Mr Second Deputy Speaker: Leader, the arrangement was that we will

give some people the chance to comment, we come and do a Bill, we will resume another commentary, then we come to another session. We even have some commemorative Statement to make, so we decided that we will do two on each Side, then later on, we do two on each Side. The Hon Deputy Minority Leader was in the second part. We still have four on each Side to go.

Osahen Afenyo-Markin: Mr Speaker, I know all that. But I am saying that what the Majority Chief Whip indicated was that we do—they had one available, so we should do one on their Side and two on our Side, then we will break and do other things and come back. What I am saying is that this new arrangement where he now says Dr Clement Apaak is going to speak is not part of the understanding we reached. So, it is fine if he wants Dr Apaak to debate and replace Hon Dickson, whose constituents—no, but that is the list—*[Interruption]*—Yes, but Mr Speaker said so on record. Mr Speaker, let us know who he is replacing. He has brought you a list, so we want to know who he is replacing because another Colleague has his constituents—*[Interruption]*—No, because the Speaker mentioned it, not me. But we have not been given the chance. But the Speaker has already placed it in the *Hansard*. Mr Speaker, which Hon Member is Hon Apaak replacing?

Mr Second Deputy Speaker: Hon Members, I do not see why you should be struggling with this. The two lists are here. Out of nine on each Side we have already covered four on each Side, so we

are left with five on each Side. So, what it means is that once Dr Clement Apaak is coming in, the last person on the list may not get the opportunity to speak. I have mentioned the name.

Mr Dafeamekpor: Mr Speaker, the Minority Leader should not do this. He should not create disaffection for this Leadership. We do not interfere with his selection, so he should not interfere with our selection.

4:01 p.m.

Osahen Afenyo-Markin: Mr Speaker, we have already given you names. Anytime we want to vary or amend, we are to indicate. What I am asking most respectfully is that, for the purpose of clarity, the respected senior counsel, who is the Chief Whip for the Majority Caucus, should indicate to us who among the four remaining speakers is replacing Dr Clement Apaak. We need to know.

Mr Second Deputy Speaker: Leader, you do not need to know. When you make changes, you just bring them to me, and I mention who is next to speak. So, if they are making changes, the changes will just have to come to me, and the person who is next will speak. Minority Leader, you have already made changes, so if they are making changes, I do not think there is anything wrong.

Yes, Deputy Minority Leader?

Ms Appiagyei: Thank you, Mr Speaker. I want to get an understanding here. Because before we started, we

recommenced the debate. The agreement was that, since they started, we had one outstanding on our Side; therefore, if we take one from their Side, I am also going to comment, so it is going to be one from each Side. Then we would move on to another Business.

What is the understanding now? Are we going to continue with the debate? And is Hon Dickson out as requested?

Mr Second Deputy Speaker: Hon Members, please, we started the debate from the Majority Side, then we came to the Minority Side. When we got to a certain point in time, we did the Bill. By then, the Majority had already done three, and the Minority had done two. That is why in the second round, the Majority has done one, and the Minority has done two. So, it is now four from each Side.

Ms Appiagyei: Mr Speaker, what I wanted to find out is, are we continuing the debate?

Mr Second Deputy Speaker: We are going to continue depending on the pleasure of the Leadership. We may pause to do something else, but we will continue. We have nine from each Side to cover and we will continue till we exhaust the list. If the Leadership decides that, we should pause and do something else, we would.

Ms Appiagyei: We would have to come to an agreement on what we want to do. Because you gave us the indication that after my comments, we are going to do something else. The Minister for

Finance is here to continue that, but they cannot continue the comments.

Mr Dafeamekpor: Why can we not continue with the comments? Hon Deputy Minority Leader, we would take one more comment from our Side. Then we would vary the Order of Business *[Interruption]* Hon Member cannot say no.

Mr Second Deputy Speaker: Hon Majority Chief Whip, we have already taken four comments from each Side, so once we take Dr Clement Apaak and another from the Minority Side, we would pause and continue with the Bill.

Mr Dafeamekpor: That is all. So why was it so circuitous?

Mr Second Deputy Speaker: So, Dr Clement Apaak, you have 15 minutes.

Dr Clement Abas Apaak (NDC — Builsa South): I am most grateful, Mr Speaker, for giving me the opportunity to contribute to the debate on the 2026 Budget Statement and Economic Policy of the John Dramani Mahama-led NDC Government as presented by Dr Ato Forson.

Mr Speaker, given that yesterday the Minister for Education was here and did justice to the Budget with regard to education, I would like to confine my comments to the matter pertaining to the allocation of GHC292 million towards the procurement and distribution of sanitary pads for our students from upper primary to junior high school.

Mr Speaker, in doing so, it is only proper that I correct some misinformation that came up yesterday during the debate and was repeated a little while ago. The Ministry of Education, which is the Ministry mandated to operationalise this far-reaching and life-changing policy, which sought to eliminate barriers that prevented our girl children from maximising educational opportunities, has achieved some dividends.

In the 2025 Budget Statement and Economic Policy, GH¢292 million was allocated for the procurement and distribution of sanitary pads. Mr Speaker, let me put on record that at no time did the Ministry of Education engage any company or contract any entity to supply sanitary pads at a unit cost per pack of 12 pieces for GH¢45.00. Mr Speaker, this is false. The Ministry segregated the total quantity of sanitary pads to be bought with the GH¢292 million into two batches. The first batch is composed of 6,607,095 packs, and the second batch is composed of 5,601,245 packs.

Mr Speaker, as I speak to you today, 6,607,173 packs have been distributed to 2,578,519 students. And it is again not accurate when the claim is made that our students in senior high schools were not included. Mr Speaker, they were. Here is the breakdown. For the students in primary school, 398,701 female students in primary 5 and 6 benefited from the sanitary pads. For those in junior high schools, 1,101,486 students benefited from the sanitary pads. And for those in secondary, Technical and Vocational

Education and Training (TVET) institutions, 968,285 students benefited.

4:11 p.m.

Mr Speaker, on the matter of great concern which has occasioned my participation in this debate, let me be specific. At no time did the Ministry procure a pack of sanitary pads composed of 12 pieces at GH¢45. The procurement was in the range of GH¢19 to GH¢24. GH¢19 was the lowest threshold and the upper threshold was GH¢24 which was per a pack. The only reason for which there is a variation in this range was because of the distance.

Clearly, a supplier moving sanitary pads from a company producing them in Accra to my region which is the Upper East Region would have to spend on transportation, given the distance. A supplier procuring in Accra and distributing to the Eastern Region would also pay for the cost of transportation, but the distance is relatively short. One of the agreements that we had with multiple supplier, not sole sourced like it was being done before, was that every supplier was mandated to work and add the cost of transportation at his or her own cost to the amounts I have stated. So, it is never true that an amount of GH¢45 was used to procure a pad.

Mr Speaker, as I speak to you, the procurement processes have concluded and the distribution of the second batch of sanitary pads, GH¢5.6 million, is currently ongoing. *[Hear1 Hear!]* So, when the Minister for Finance makes reference to the quantity that has been

used as a basis to calculate and to arrive at GH¢45 per pack, that does not include the second batch which is currently being distributed; these are the facts.

We promised the good people of Ghana to run an open, transparent and an accountable government and that is exactly what we are doing. I recognise that our Colleagues have been on their knees, praying fervently, day and night, wishing for a scandal. They will not get a scandal— *[Hear! Hear!]*— There is no scandal. No prices have been inflated. Senior high school students have benefited and we will account duly to Ghanaians.

Mr Speaker, this is what I wanted to clarify. Having done so, let me add that the sanitary pads are benefiting Ghanaians and our girl child. The easy availability of sanitary pads has brought about a new level of confidence for our girl children in school. It is also increasing retention and we are beginning to see an improvement in educational outcomes. Let no one make a mistake, this is perhaps one of the most important interventions any Government has ever made.

Mr Speaker, since I still have a few more minutes, let me take this opportunity to remind our Friends opposite, that H.E. John Dramani Mahama, the nation builder, the man who keeps his promise, he, who was accused, falsely so, of planning to collapse or cancel the Free Senior High School Programme and he is the only President who has taken practical steps not only to sustain and improve it by allocating a whopping GH¢4.2 billion,

but in addition, he has made provision towards ending the obnoxious double track system by allocating a specific amount of GH¢1.1 billion —*[Hear! Hear!]*—This is the man they said was going to cancel the Free Senior High School. They could not do what he has done in the entire eight years. He has done it in only one year— *[Interruption]*—only nine months.

Mr Speaker, as if that was not enough, Mr John Dramani Mahama, since taking over the reins of governance of this country, has made sure that adequate provision is made to feed our wards in the senior high schools. If anyone in this hallowed Chamber can stand up and tell us from 7th January till today, an occasion where students had to demonstrate or schools had to be shut down due to inadequate food, I would cede my month's salary to that Member. *[Hear! Hear!]*

Mr Speaker, since H.E. John Dramani Mahama took over the reins of this country, we have not heard of expired food. We have not heard of students eating the food they used to describe as “donkey saliva” or *gari jollof*— *[Hear! Hear!]*— Students consume nutritious and balanced diets. They eat eggs, sardines and eat beans, not weevil-infested beans. This is the change Ghanaians voted for and that is exactly what Mr John Dramani Mahama is delivering.

Mr Speaker, let me further indicate—

Mr Second Deputy Speaker: Hon Member, the use of the “weevil-infested beans” please, do away with that.

Dr Apaak: Mr Speaker, these are facts. [*Uproar*] As a Member of the Public Accounts Committee (PAC)—any Member of PAC would testify that even the Auditor-General captured this in the Auditor-General's Report.

Mr Second Deputy Speaker: Dr Clement Apaak, the facts are subjective. I am not aware. You may be aware, but somebody else may not be aware of that. Just withdraw that part for me.

Dr Apaak: Mr Speaker, then I would withdraw that and say students are no longer being fed unwholesome food. [*Hear! Hear!*]

Again, in the area of education, for the first time in the history of our Republic, our sons, daughters, brothers and sisters who have disabilities are enjoying free education at the tertiary level. That was not enough for His Excellency the President.

His Excellency the President working with the Minister for Education, is introducing another intervention that would provide free education for learners with disabilities from the very basic level to the senior high school level, then when they transition to the university, they get free education.

So, essentially, H.E. John Dramani Mahama is introducing a policy that would make education from kindergarten to university free for all persons with disability. [*Hear! Hear!*]

Mr Second Deputy Speaker: Be winding up please, your time is almost up.

Dr Apaak: For eight years, they spent our money excavating the biggest hole on the surface of the universe. They had no foresight. They spent our hard-earned resources chartering luxurious flights so that they can freshen up in the air to the detriment of Ghanaians.

So, let no one make a mistake that H.E. John Dramani Mahama and the NDC Government—

Mr Second Deputy Speaker: Hon Members, we turn to Mr Matthew Nyindam. [*Hear! Hear!*]

Mr Matthew Nyindam (NPP — Kpandai): Thank you Hon—[*Uproar*]

Mr Second Deputy Speaker: Mr Dafeamekpor, the Majority have had five commentaries, the Minority, four. We are now going to the fifth.

4:21 p.m.

Mr Dafeamekpor: Mr Speaker, I am making this intervention on Constitutional grounds. Yesterday, 24th November, 2025, the High Court of Tamale ordered that the outcome of the election—these are very serious matters, that the outcome of the 7th December elections 2024, which brought the Hon Matthew Nyindam to this House, as MP for Kpandai was flawed, and therefore that election has been ordered to be rerun.

Mr Speaker, *ipso facto*, Hon Matthew Nyindam is no longer a Member of this House. He is not. Hear me, so that he can respond. So, by

operation of law, he is no longer a Member of this House with a voice. That is one.

Mr Speaker, two, we have received the court orders and received proof of service. The orders of the court have been duly served on Parliament. It was served yesterday. It will serve the Minority to listen to me in silence. If they are minded to respond, then they can do so.

Mr Second Deputy Speaker: Hon Members, please, let us listen to him.

Mr Dafeamekpor: Mr Speaker, I have a copy of the proof of service of the orders of the Tamale High Court, dated, 24th November, 2025 and served to Parliament. The orders of the court were served by the court bailiff of the High Court, Accra. He is called Solomon Osafo, bailiff of the High Court, Accra and I have the affidavit of service. I will make all these available to the Table Office.

Mr Speaker, by operation of law, the Hon Matthew Nyindam can no longer participate in our proceedings. If he is minded to appeal the decision of the High Court, it is his right, and he has done so. But it trite that mere filing of an appeal does not operate as a stay of execution of the court's orders.

Mr Speaker, further, a mere filing of a stay of execution—please, there are two processes involved here. I have seen both copies. He has filed a notice of appeal. It does not operate as a stay against the execution of the orders of the

Tamale High Court. A mere filing of a stay of execution application also does not operate as a stay against the execution of the orders of the court. So, Parliament, having been duly served, has the duty under law to ensure that the Hon Matthew Nyindam is no longer extended courtesies by the House as extended to Hon Members.

Mr Speaker, I am not raising this matter whimsically, because precedence will guide us. When the Hon James Gyakyé Quayson was ordered by the court that he should go through rerun of his elections, Members of this Side at the time, mainly led by the now Minority Leader, spoke vociferously against the fact that the Hon James Gyakyé Quayson cannot be entertained in this House. The issue was raised by Prof Kingsley Nyarko. He used to sit here and that matter caught fire on this Floor. Eventually, the Hon James Gyakyé Quayson had to leave. So, these matters are a beaten path. This is a path that we have travelled. Precedents have been set and laid. So, nobody can urge upon this House today that the Hon Matthew Nyindam must have a voice today. It would not happen—[Uproar]—So, the orders of the High Court are directed at Parliament as well as the Electoral Commission to order for a rerun of the election within 30 days, upon the grant of that order.

Mr Speaker, there is no contrary order from the High Court, properly constituted, nor the Court of Appeal. Staying that order of the High Court, and me as the Majority Chief Whip of this Side, we will not sit and disobey the

orders of the Court. So, we went through the processes painfully and got a judicial pronouncement. By all means, they can hold your press conferences outside and say things against the judiciary. We would not do that. We will observe the orders of the Court. If they are minded, the tournament for doing so is in the courtroom. The precincts of Parliament and the foyers of Parliament are forum non-convenience.

Mr Speaker, a year ago, if I may remind this House, when there were contentious matters and the Minority Leader, then Majority Leader, declared as Minority Leader and disagreed, he went to court to seek a judicial interpretation. Within two hours, he got a court order. He mounted a press conference on the steps of this Parliament and praised the judiciary to the high heavens, less than 12 months ago. Today, we are told that the judiciary is not fair. But these are not matters that we will table here. So, I am only bringing this matter to the attention of the House, that Parliament has been properly served. It is not as though Parliament is not aware. Parliament is properly served. The Speaker, the Clerk and the Legal Department have been served.

Mr Speaker, so, the Hon Matthew Nyindam is now a *persona non grata* on this Floor and to the precincts of this Parliament, as a Member of Parliament, the Court says he must go back and go through the processes. If he is duly re-elected, he can come back but for now, he cannot. I would not belabour the point.

Mr Speaker, on the totality of my submission, I pray that he must even be marched out of the Chamber by precedence. I am not saying so. Precedence set by the opposite Side when they were here and Hon James Gyakyé Quayson went back and returned triumphantly. So, what was good yesterday must be good today. As Leaders, we must live by principles. That is why when they set bad precedents and principles, they should know that it may hurt them tomorrow.

Mr Speaker, I have the backing of my Side to demand that Hon Matthew Nyindam does not participate further in the Business of this House until he goes through re-election.

Mr Speaker, I so submit—[*Hear! Hear!*].

Mr Second Deputy Speaker: Yes, Minority Leader, let us hear you.

4:31 p.m.

Osahen Afenyo-Markin: Mr Speaker, I have listened to my Colleague on the other Side. He makes certain claims. I will address the factual claims and the legal submissions. So, let me first deal with the factual issues and address the inconsistencies and inaccuracies thereto.

Mr Speaker, never as a Deputy Leader or as a Leader of this House, did I advocate that Mr Gyakyé Quayson, having lost a High Court case, should be marched out of this Chamber. I want the Hon Member who is attempting to quote

me to bring that *Hansard*. I challenge him on that.

Mr Speaker, I am surprised that Mr Dafeamekpor is making an argument, and according to him, he is grounding it on principles. Let me spend a bit of time on Mr Gyakyee Quayson's case. After the High Court ruling, he filed an appeal for a stay of execution, this House never denied Gyakyee Quayson and his right of entry or his right to be heard.

Mr Speaker, that is why I love the *Hansard*. Let us be very clear when we say that we are relying on precedents. In the Eighth Parliament, where the Rt Hon Speaker Bagbin presided, the judgment of the High Court on the citizenship matter did not automatically lead to an order because, for Mr Gyakyee Quayson to be ordered out, it had to be done by the Speaker. My brother on the Other Side, whom I so much respect, I have no doubts on the efficacy of his legal knowledge; we learnt together, we studied and passed our exams together. He knows how much I respect him. I want him to give me proof that in the Eighth Parliament, the Speaker read a Communication and directed accordingly; there is none. I want him to bring the *Hansard* with proof that the First Deputy Speaker, or your good self, who was the Second Deputy Speaker in the Eighth Parliament, ordered Mr Gyakyee Quayson out of this Chamber because there was a High Court order. I am aware that the matter came up, but no such order was directed because I also remember that their Side argued that he had filed a stay of execution pending the hearing of his appeal.

Mr Speaker, for the avoidance of doubt, whereas in the Gyakyee Quayson matter, the judgment of the courts was made available to all parties, it will interest Mr Dafeamekpor, who is today arguing that an Hon Member who has been regularly elected, sworn in, be removed because there is an order of a court. When the judge himself said his judgement is not ready, and that his judgement will be ready on Friday. That is what the judge said in an open court.

Mr Speaker, the right to be heard does not *simpliciter* mean that you create just the opportunity. That right must manifest in the process of hearing, which would be called a fair hearing.

Mr Speaker, the next leg of his argument is that a stay of execution does not operate as a stay. With respect, I have spent years in the courtroom, and I have been an active practising lawyer in the superior court of this country. I know my Friend to be a practising lawyer as well. Law and politics may have interlocking interests, but I beg to submit that where the interest of politics is that of convenience, that interest must give way to the law, and no submission should be advanced to make convenience subdue due process and law.

Mr Speaker, what Mr Dafeamekpor is directing you to do is highly inappropriate and improper. Mr Speaker, he adds on to his submissions with a very dangerous precedent. A while ago, although I said it on a lighter note, he was concerned that such words, such phrases ought not to be used. I agreed with him. How then does he, as a Leader, in

making his case, create an impression that this is a Chamber of brawl? This is not a Chamber of brawl, we all discuss and jaw-jaw. So, for him to say that it will not happen, and that they will not allow it, no. It is no more about — *[Uproar]*—

Mr Speaker, Mr Dafeamekpor has always been calling on my Side to hear him in silence. There are people who try to create all manner of things, but they do not have the heart to receive back. So, they should check their body language before they start reporting to the Rt Hon Speaker that they are being intimidated. They intimidate, insinuate, and act up, yet when they are getting a bite of their actions, then they are crying. If they do not have the energy, they should be quiet and listen. After all, I have been here, and this is my fourth term.

Mr Speaker, we are not here with manpower; we are not doing a macho business in this Chamber. So, we will be told that a certain 189 has the macho power to move Hon Nyindam out, no.

4:41 p.m.

Mr Speaker, Hon Matthew Nyindam, as the applicant himself said, and the applicant here is Hon Dafeamekpor, himself conceded that he has become aware that there is a stay of execution that has been duly filed. If the High Court judge, who at first instance will hear that application is minded, he should speedily determine for the man to pursue his case at another level. This is a democracy. Let us allow due process of law. Let us not, for whatever convenience, attempt to frustrate others.

Mr Speaker, we know of what happened on election night when Members on this Side who had won their elections, through machoism and attacks, were denied their votes. We know what we have all gone through. So, is this nation today encouraging violence, machoism as a way to move our democracy forward? I beg to say, no. And it should never come out of the mouth of a Member of Parliament that he will not allow. He will not allow by what means? After all, in a worst-case scenario, if the Member remains here or decides to participate in the words of Haruna Iddrisu, Minority Leader as he then was, the decision—

Mr Ayariga — *rose* —

Osahen Afenyo-Markin: Mr Speaker, I am dealing with *Hansard*. *[Interruption]*—No. Yes, do not worry. Leader, knows what stuff I am made of. I will not get into waters that I am unsure my ability to swim ashore. I am very careful, extremely careful.

Mr Speaker, Hon Haruna Iddrisu, Minority Leader as he then was, in the matter of Gyakye Quayson, where a court process had been served on Parliament and on Hon Gyakye Quayson, at the swearing-in, argued that the filing of the injunction—Mr Speaker, in that case it was even an injunction order, an express court order, where there was no process that had been filed by Hon Gyakye Quayson. Even so, the contention of the respected Minority Leader as he then was, Hon Haruna Iddrisu, was to the effect that if he decides to go against a court order, it is

his sole responsibility. As part of the jurisprudence of this country, disobedience to a court order amounts to a contempt. And contempt of court is a quasi-criminal offence for which the one who is disobeying the court is solely responsible.

So, Mr Speaker, this debating Chamber must not metamorphose into a constitutional chamber. We should not attempt to advance a constitutional argument and make a constitutional determination where we know that there is another chamber responsible for that. Today, it may be Hon Nyindam. So, for anybody to make an argument of convenience and try to shape it in a certain form, quote it in a certain form, to impose it on us, Mr Speaker, we will not accept it. I therefore pray that his request or prayer to you be rejected.

Mr Speaker, the Hon Member who is seated in this Chamber, who is part of the 87 of the Minority Caucus, and it is his turn to debate, unless our Friend, the Majority Chief Whip, wants to use a physical means to disobey your order, or your ruling, or do anything to otherwise disturb the peace of this Chamber—He cannot invite you to make a constitutional pronouncement to deny Hon Nyindam his right to represent his people who have elected him for four years. Hon Nyindam has not slept on his rights.

Mr Speaker, I have made all the legal submissions, I have addressed the factual inaccuracies, as well as all the factual inaccuracies, the allegations that he made bringing me in, that I, as Majority

Leader, made argument to the effect that Hon Gyakye Quayson should be denied entry, and that the Majority then denied Hon Gyakye Quayson entry, never happened. The Majority never did that because the Majority then had no such powers. If there are manoeuvring to get the Chair to subject this Parliament to the pleasure of the Majority, that must cease. It is not going to help democracy.

Mr Speaker, the last leg of my argument, I am aware of the Vincent Assafuah case. The ratio in that matter must be distinguished. It is very clear; nobody should misconstrue that. What the Supreme Court through my Lord Kulendi said in the Assafuah case is different in form and shape from this very matter. Where he argued when a party files an injunction against a state institution or an organ of state, until that application is granted, it does not deny that state institution or that organ of state from performing its statutory or constitutional mandate must be distinguished from the matter before us. This is a matter of human rights, the rights of a duly elected Member of Parliament. He has not filed that process to stop a state institution from performing its function. That is not what he is doing.

He has been elected *bona fide*, you know that, for four years, and we know that. We cannot create any temporal vacuum whatsoever.

4:51 p.m.

Mr Speaker, the issue of representation is a *sine qua non* matter. Representation of people—when Justice

Atuguba, in the Akufo-Addo and others against John Dramani Mahama and another — [*Hear! Hear!*] — This is a time for all Colleagues to learn. So please, I need our attention. These are very serious arguments. They would not always get me on my feet to advance such serious constitutional arguments. So they should pay attention.

Mr Speaker, in the matter of Akufo-Addo and others against John Dramani Mahama and another, Justice Atuguba speaking on behalf of the majority said that the argument of the plaintiff on annulment of votes because same were not signed by the presiding officers as provided for by the regulation must not be entertained because there had been regular votes and those votes must be respected. Justice Atuguba invoked the prudence rule. I am not here to educate or give a lecture on the rule of prudence. I am not going to do that. It is a matter that the applicant himself knows. When procedure and prudence clash, procedure will give way to prudence.

And therefore, it will be prudent for us to allow Hon Nyindam to remain with us as a Member of Parliament because it is a constitutional right he is exercising for and on behalf of the Kpandai people. Mr Speaker, we cannot say that he should be walked out or the Majority cannot say that they will not allow him to be in this Chamber. There is no such precedent. When the Gyakye Quayson matter occurred, there was no directive from the chair. Neither was there a *macho* power from the Majority to walk him out of this Chamber. It did not happen. He remained a Member of Parliament. He continued to receive his

salary; his salary was not stopped. His car was not taken from him. His benefits were not taken from him.

Mr Speaker, he was allowed to go through the full process all the way to the Supreme Court until the Supreme Court made its determination. Then, eventually, there was a by-election. So, what is good for the goose is good for the gander. What was done by the NDC Minority as they were in the Eighth Parliament must be done for Mr Matthew Nyindam, Hon Member for Kpandai, who is with the Minority Caucus.

Mr Speaker, without more, I would resume my seat and pray that you allow him to make his submissions as part of his own contribution on this matter before us. Thank you so much indeed.

Mr Second Deputy Speaker: Hon Leader, you made the application, and I have heard you.

Mr Dafeamekpor: Mr Speaker, these are very serious matters. Hear me.

Mr Second Deputy Speaker: Hon Leader, we have so many things to do today.

Mr Dafeamekpor: Mr Speaker, I agree.

Mr Second Deputy Speaker: Hon Leader, I have not given you the platform. Put off the microphone first.

Hon Members, I listened to the application by the Majority Chief Whip, and I have also listened to the Minority

Leader. The Speaker of Parliament has directed me to freeze this particular matter relating to Hon Matthew Nyindam. Therefore, I am not going to make any comments on it. I pray that we hold on with the commentary on the Budget Statement and Economic Policy and move on to something else. So that is my directive.

The Rt Hon Speaker will take on this matter when he takes the seat. So, Leadership, let us look at something else to do.

Mr Dafeamekpor: Mr Speaker, may we take the item numbered 20, and that will be the Third Reading of the Value Added Tax Bill. I just realised that the Minister for Finance has stepped out of the Chamber. So may I seek your leave to permit the Deputy Minister for Finance to do this on his behalf?

Mr Second Deputy Speaker: Yes. So, I have done a lot for today. I will let the First Deputy Speaker also continue.

4:59 p.m. —

[HON FIRST DEPUTY SPEAKER,
MR BERNARD AHIAFOR, IN THE
CHAIR]

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Hon Deputy Minister for Finance. Let me hear you.

BILL — THIRD READING

Value Added Tax Bill, 2025

Deputy Minister for Finance (Mr Thomas Nyarko Ampem): Mr Speaker, I beg to *move*:

That the Value Added Tax Bill, 2025, be now read the Third time.

Vice-Chairperson of the Committee (Mr Richard Acheampong): Mr Speaker, I beg to second the Motion.

Question put and Motion agreed to.

The Value Added Tax Bill, 2025—
read the Third time and passed.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Hon Members, yes?

Mr Dafeamekpor: Mr Speaker, we may have to go back to the Motion numbered 8(a) to take comments on the Budget Statement and Economic Policy.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Hon Members, I have heard my Colleague Speaker loud and clear that the instruction is to defer the issue under consideration as well as the continuation of the commentary on the estimates.

5:01 p.m.

So, I intend not to vary the commentary on the Budget Statement and Economic Policy. Once these matters are deferred, I do not intend to vary that directive. So, Hon Members, in the circumstances, we are yet to conclude some issues on the other Bills. I do not know whether we have gone beyond five hours or not. Hon Members, the indication is clear. So, if you have not done beyond five hours, let us do the needful.

Mr Dafeamekpor: Mr Speaker, we have done four and a half hours.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Very well. I expect the needful in the circumstances.

Majority Chief Whip (Mr Rockson-Nelson Etse Kwami Dafeamekpor): Mr Speaker, in the absence of any further Business, I move that the House be adjourned until tomorrow, midday.

Second Deputy Majority Whip (Mr Richard Acheampong): Mr Speaker, I beg to second the Motion.

Question put and Motion agreed to.

ADJOURNMENT

The House was accordingly adjourned at 5:04 p.m. till Thursday, 27th November, 2025 at 12 noon.

Editor's Note

This Official Report was corrected by the House on 9th December, 2025.